

House, Household, and Home

Revisiting Anthropological and Policy Frameworks through Postearthquake Reconstruction Experiences in Nepal

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Through ethnographic fieldwork and analysis of policy documents about private housing reconstruction in the wake of Nepal's devastating 2015 earthquakes, we show how the contemporary "house," "household," and "home" are key sites of regulation for the state, as well as for the development and humanitarian organizations that work within it. Our discussion lays bare a more general set of questions about the relationships between these categories that remain unresolved in the anthropological literature, as well as in domains of policy practice that build on it. The experience of postearthquake reconstruction in Nepal has highlighted conceptual limitations in the existing legal definitions of ownership and residence and challenged people's sense of belonging at the affective level. This is in part due to conditions of high mobility that affect patterns of kinship and sociality and demand an understanding of infrastructure as process. We propose a tripartite analytical framework that recognizes the relational complexities between the concepts of "house," "household," and "home" and argue that careful attention to their definitions in both anthropological and policy contexts matters because those terminologies drive processes of change that may begin in moments of natural disaster but extend far beyond that temporal horizon to reconfigure lives.

For example, a garment becomes a real garment only in the act of being worn; a house where no one lives is in fact not a real house. (Karl Marx, *Grundrisse*, 1993 [1939])

Introduction

Nearly five years after Nepal's devastating 2015 earthquakes, we visited Borang, a mountain village of about 250 families in Nepal's Dhading district. As one of 14 severely affected districts, Dhading was an active site for the National Reconstruction Authority's (NRA) private housing reconstruction grant program, which offered up to 300,000 Nepali rupees (NPR; approx. US\$2,500) to eligible families to reconstruct their houses. Yet here, in a remote location, most residents had not expected any state support and had simply patched up their large stone and wood residences as soon as they could.

When state representatives finally arrived almost a year after the earthquake to offer private housing reconstruction grants, people were faced with a conundrum: to qualify, it seemed,

they were required to build a new structure that met earthquake-resilient building codes. The grant could not be used to recoup costs they had already expended. So most residents set about building very small one-roomed earthquake-resilient structures that met the formal requirements of the grant program. These small new structures joined the already renovated larger traditional homes, usually on adjacent plots of land, to create a patchwork built environment (fig. 1). Most of the new structures were locked and used primarily as storage sheds for grain or farming equipment (fig. 2).

As we walked through this landscape in January 2020, we struck up a conversation with a woman who stood brushing her hair in the doorway of a small new earthquake-resilient structure. "Older sister," we asked, "is this your house (Nepali: *Didi, yo tapaiko ghar ho?*)?" Gesturing into the doorway with a look of

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Figure 1. The patchwork built environment of Borang, 2020. Photo: Sara Shneiderman.

disdain, the woman responded: “This? This is not a house.” Seeing that the structure contained two beds and other apparent trappings of day-to-day life, we were confused and asked further, “What is it, then?” “This?” said the woman, peering into the doorway of the one-roomed structure. “This is an earthquake house (*bhukampa ghar*).” “That,” she continued, gesturing toward a few pieces of tin across the courtyard, “is my house. We have not rebuilt it yet because my husband only recently returned from working abroad. Come and see.” Upon ducking

inside the tin doorway, we could see the wood pillars of an older building still standing inside the temporary shell of tin. “For now we are sleeping in the earthquake house,” the woman continued, “but soon we will rebuild our own home (*hamro aphno ghar*).”

There is no semantic difference in Nepali between “house” and “home”; *ghar* is used to denote both (Nelson 2017). However, it was clear from the interaction just described, and many others throughout our three-year collaborative research project, that residents recognize an experiential difference



Figure 2. One-roomed house in Borang, 2018. Photo: Prakash Chandra Subedi.

between “house” as a material form and “home” as an affective site of belonging. They also clearly distinguish between these two concepts and that of the “household,” with the latter understood as a kin-based network, all members of which may or may not reside physically within the boundaries of either the house or the home. Nepali experiences of postearthquake reconstruction therefore raise a series of critical social-scientific questions about how the conceptual categories of house, home, and household are differentially defined by scholars, policymakers, and residents themselves and how these categories produce both material and social transformation.

From the first days of immediate postearthquake relief in spring 2015, through subsequent phases of recovery and reconstruction, both government and international/nongovernmental organization (I/NGO)-implemented policies toward Nepal’s earthquake-affected citizens have vacillated between a focus on the household and the house as the meaningful unit for the allocation of aid to families ultimately determined to have lost their residence. Yet neither of these concepts alone captures the full affective meaning of home as experienced by people living through the process of reconstruction. Taking the shifting relationships between these conceptual categories and the actors that produce them as a starting point, our article interrogates these categories as framed by both anthropologists and policymakers through an analysis of ethnographic material from three earthquake-affected districts of the country: Bhaktapur, Dhading, and Sindhuupalchowk.

In so doing, we seek to forge a rapprochement between structuralist-symbolic (Lévi-Straussian) approaches to the house as unit of sociality, structuralist-materialist (Marxist) approaches to the household as a unit of production, and culturalist-ideational (Carsten and Hugh-Jones 1995) approaches to the home as a unit of identity formation. We argue for a tripartite analytical framework that recognizes the relational complexities between the concepts of house, household, and home, following a careful attention to their definitions in specific ethnographic as well as policy contexts. This proposition is scaffolded by four thematic subarguments regarding the relationships between infrastructure as process; development and reconstruction; belonging and mobility; and ownership, kinship, and citizenship.

Infrastructure as Process

Insights from the anthropology of disaster, as situated within the broader transdisciplinary field of disaster studies, encourage us to foreground process and change in considering the house as a form of infrastructural development (Barrios 2014, 2017b). Understanding infrastructure as process moves the anthropological debate over the relationship between house and home beyond a dualistic framing of materiality versus sociality, instead pushing us toward a focus on the entanglement of these elements in broader processes of transformation.

The burgeoning anthropological literature on infrastructure carves out a scholarly niche at the intersection of social, natural, and engineering sciences by defining infrastructure as

an extended material assemblage that generates effects and structures social relations (for overviews see Anand, Gupta, and Appel 2018; Harvey, Jensen, and Morita 2017). Several scholars have taken up these concerns in Nepal, with a focus on large-scale installations such as roads and hydropower (Gurung 2021; Murton and Lord 2020; Murton 2020; Rankin et al. 2017). We build on their insights to consider the more intimate microscale of private housing as a form of infrastructure (Boyle and Shneiderman 2020). We suggest that, taken together, the approximately one million private residential structures requiring reconstruction in Nepal create an infrastructural assemblage that shapes subjectivities and political practice at a massive scale, just as roads, hydropower plants, and other large-scale infrastructural forms do.

Development and Reconstruction

Conversely, we contribute to disaster studies by considering how spatiotemporally specific frameworks for needs assessment in postdisaster contexts might benefit from engagement with anthropology’s long history of attention to the fundamental human practices of creating shelter and social organization in relation to each other. Our discussion challenges the perceived divide between theoretical and applied anthropology by building on James Ferguson’s (2005) formulation of development and anthropology as “evil twins.” Ferguson asserts, “A real reconfiguration of the epistemic terrain that makes most academic work so irrelevant and powerless in its encounter with development may require . . . that we engage in some foundational work on our own disciplinary houses” (151). In Nepal, reconstruction may be understood as unfolding within the epistemic terrain of development, in which most of the governmental and nongovernmental entities engaged in long-term reconstruction were embedded prior to the disaster. As Edward Simpson and Michele Serafini (2019) put it, “the dialect of post-disaster recovery” in Nepal draws on the “well-rooted rhetoric of development” (205).

This is evident in online donor materials, such as an entry in the World Bank’s “Results Briefs” series titled “Post-Earthquake Reconstruction in Nepal: Rebuilding Lives, One Home at a Time.” Here the \$700 million in financing contributed by the International Development Association to the Government of Nepal via the Earthquake Housing Reconstruction Project (EHRP) is described as “focused on promoting resilient construction practices, empowering women, leaving no one behind, promoting good governance, and supporting overall economic development.”¹

1. <https://www.worldbank.org/en/results/2020/09/29/post-earthquake-reconstruction-in-nepal-rebuilding-lives-one-home-at-a-time> (accessed January 29, 2021). The EHRP was one of several funding streams comprising the NRA’s operating budget for private housing reconstruction grants. All together, \$4.4 billion was pledged at the June 2015 International Conference on Nepal’s Reconstruction. A full list of donors is available at <http://www.nra.gov.np/en/agencyprofile/donor>.

Indeed, Jennifer Barenstein argues that articulating clear definitions of “house” and “household” and developing a contextual understanding of their relationship to each other in disaster zones are critical steps in implementing the basic human right to adequate housing enshrined in the UN Human Rights Council framework. In her analysis of reconstruction in Tamil Nadu, India, after the 2004 tsunami,

questions arose such as what does “all affected people” mean? How does such a promise account for different degrees of disaster impacts? Should each household get a house? How should a household be defined? Does it make sense to give the same housing support to a small nuclear and large extended family? If a young couple lived with their elderly parents, who should get a house? Such questions were not, however, addressed in formulating reconstruction policy. (Barenstein 2016:255)

More than 10 years later, the same questions were left unresolved in Nepal’s reconstruction policy. We suggest that directing anticipatory attention to these questions—and the social categories that underlie them—from both anthropological and policymaking perspectives may contribute to mitigating the negative effects of future disasters for those most affected.

Belonging and Mobility

Immediately after the 2015 earthquakes, relief was distributed at the local level on an ad hoc basis. In this context, preexisting economic- and kinship-based definitions of “the household” familiar from the Nepal Census, the Living Standards Survey, and various other development initiatives played an informal role in influencing decisions. However, the subsequent reconstruction program focused on the physical unit of the house and its linkage to land ownership as a prerequisite for reconstruction grants. Ultimately, full recovery might be understood as achieving a holistic sense of belonging in the transformed postdisaster environment that “home” conveys (Baniya 2018). Our data show that in many cases, this has not easily been achieved.

These transforming relationships between citizens, the state, the built environment, and the landscape are situated within a context of high mobility.² This also complicates the presumed isomorphic relationships between house, household, and home, instead creating a nested set of overlapping networks and structures. Much recent scholarship has highlighted the critical role that migration for labor and education plays in Nepal’s political economy and sociality (Childs and Choedup 2018; Craig 2020; Sijapati et al. 2017; Sharma 2018; Sunam 2020; Zharkevich 2019), a reality for residents of Borang and many other villages. We

argue that houses become important anchors for disaggregated household-based livelihood strategies when many members may not reside in the physical house itself yet its existence remains central to their own ability to travel away from it.

As the woman quoted in the opening to this article mentioned, the rebuild of her original house was delayed because her husband was away working outside of the country. This had made it difficult for her to enroll as a beneficiary in the private housing reconstruction program, because her name was not on the land title deed, yet her husband had not been present when beneficiaries were first identified to pursue the process himself. Attention to mobility therefore reveals how policies based on implicitly sedentarist conceptualizations of the structural form of the house and the social form of the household as coterminous and fixed in place may miss critical dimensions of these categories at the experiential level.

In making this argument, we seek a middle way through the theoretical terrain of the new mobilities paradigm, which has often pitched sedentarist and nomad metaphysics in opposition to each other (Cresswell 2006; Malkki 1992). We instead acknowledge both the mobile reality of contemporary Nepali lives and their mooring in place (Hannam, Sheller, and Urry 2006). If the village can be understood as a set of social relations (Shneiderman 2015a) in contexts of high mobility, the house materializes these relations in infrastructural form, linking people to place and therefore creating the conditions for their movement away from it.

This insight nuances our interpretation of the epigraph from Marx at the beginning of this article: a “real” house need not be lived in at all times by all members of the household(s) associated with it. Indeed, affective attachments from afar, plus material investment through remittances, may be critical to both the structure’s material viability and its social meaning, just as its ongoing existence can provide an anchor for mobile livelihoods. This recognition helps to move beyond the tropes of “real” and “false” victims or beneficiaries, binary categorizations that emerged in Nepali public discourse to allege corruption (Limbu et al. 2019a). As Cresswell (2006) notes, “the consequences of a sedentarist metaphysics for mobile people are severe” (27). The experiences of earthquake-affected people in Nepal draw attention to how such consequences can be imposed not only at borders or along routes of transit but also “at home” through development and humanitarian policies and practices that may label certain houses—and the people associated with them—as false and therefore undeserving of support.

Ownership, Kinship, Citizenship

Our ethnography of postearthquake private housing reconstruction takes up Janet Carsten’s call for

a research project . . . to illuminate not just how houses over the long term enfold each other, and how even abandoned and destroyed houses have their material and imaginary

2. Remittances account for over a quarter of Nepal’s GDP. Between 2009 and 2017, the government of Nepal issued 3,554,683 permits for migrant workers seeking jobs abroad—approximately 12% of the country’s population (Government of Nepal 2018).

"afterlife," but also the deep interconnections running between family life, work life and the political life of the state. (Carsten 2018:114)

We show how the contemporary house, household, and home in Nepal are key sites of regulation for the state, as well as for the development and humanitarian organizations that work within it. These concepts also define important arenas of social and cultural reproduction for those who inhabit houses, belong to households, and maintain homes. Therefore, the instrumentalization of these concepts by the state and its donors to achieve normative reconstruction outcomes worked to restructure understandings of citizenship, as well as kinship relations and patterns of sociality. Andrew Haxby (2017) highlights this dynamic in his portrayal of three Nepali households in the near-term aftermath: "bureaucratic zones have become a key space where household members are reworking their futures, and where the virtues of kinship are being reassessed" (67). Our discussion of how such dynamics unfolded in practice over the five years after the earthquakes explores ethnographically how these categories relate to each other in the discourses and practices of diverse actors, revealing a complex terrain of negotiation through which anthropological, policy, and experiential categories are coproduced.

Ultimately, we suggest that experiences of postearthquake reconstruction have highlighted conceptual difficulties with existing legal definitions of ownership and residence and challenged people's sense of belonging at the affective level. This is an ironic outcome for a program that was promoted as an "owner-driven" model of reconstruction,³ pushing us to think further about the definition of "ownership" and the material and social units in relation to which it is defined. We argue that careful attention to definitions of "house," "household," and "home" in both anthropological and policy contexts matters because those terminologies drive material and social processes of change that may begin in moments of natural disaster but extend far beyond that temporal horizon to reconfigure the very shape of communities themselves.

A Note on Terminology

Our objective is not to appropriate local terminologies to propose universalizing definitions for "house," "household," or "home." Rather, we draw on the Nepali concepts of *ghar* (house) *chulo* (hearth), and *gharduri* (legally registered household) as deployed by our interlocutors to demonstrate how important it is for both anthropologists and policymakers to arrive at context-specific definitions and apply them consistently in practice—particularly when resources are attached. We ex-

plore these concepts in depth in subsequent sections but offer brief definitions here. *Ghar* refers to the house, in the material sense of the physical structure as well as the male lineage that is often associated with it in idealized structural form. *Chulo* refers to the hearth, or communal cooking space, used to denote the social unit of the household as embodied in the lived experience of actual (often messy) kinship relations and residential patterns at a particular moment in time.⁴ *Gharduri* refers to the legally registered household unit, which may in practice be spread across multiple *ghar* or encompass multiple *chulo*. We explore these terms across three definitional scales: (1) everyday conversational use in our field sites, (2) nationally implemented policy frameworks, (3) and global anthropological theory. While we foreground local terminologies, we do not abstract general definitions from them. Our goal is instead to show why attention to local conceptual frameworks is so important for policy implementation and how anthropological engagement might help mediate between these two scales.

Methodology and Background

Nepal has long been a prominent site for both anthropological theory building and innovation in development practice. Our work is positioned at the intersection of these approaches in a self-conscious manner that attempts to harness the productive tensions experienced within the context of a large collaborative international research partnership.⁵ The knowledge we produce draws on the work of partnership members from multiple disciplines at different points within their personal career trajectories who were variously trained and employed within North American, European, and Asian university and NGO institutional frameworks.⁶

Field sites in the three districts of Bhaktapur, Dhading, and Sindhupalchowk (fig. 3) together demonstrated important variations in terms of demography, geography, economy, rural-urban dynamics, and proximity to state presence, which influenced the reconstruction process in each site differently.⁷ Bhaktapur Municipality offers a view into the challenges of urban housing reconstruction as well as the reconstruction of major heritage sites (fig. 4). The village of Borang located in the northern part of Dhading district was chosen as a rural counterpart to Bhaktapur in terms of housing reconstruction and because it was a site of the technical assistance program, Baliyo Ghar, implemented by the National Society for Earthquake

3. As highlighted in the NRA's "Guiding Principles" (http://www.nra.gov.np/en/pages/view/adlq2bM2oc0EFjPt1sQ2f3KL_7X8L_QuYMCnGtYiTU). This contrasts with earlier state-driven reconstruction programs in the region, such as in Gujarat, India (Simpson 2013), and Sri Lanka (Gamburd 2013).

4. See Pettigrew (2013) for a discussion of the political and familial importance of the hearth.

5. See <https://elmn.arts.ubc.ca/>.

6. Further details of our collaboration and its limitations are described in Aijazi et al. (2021).

7. We recognize that the specific localities in which we conducted fieldwork cannot be taken as representative of the districts in which they are situated as a whole. Nearby villages with similar demographics had different house-building styles before the earthquake and have experienced different reconstruction outcomes, depending on a host of factors such as road access, political connections, and locally specific cultural practices.

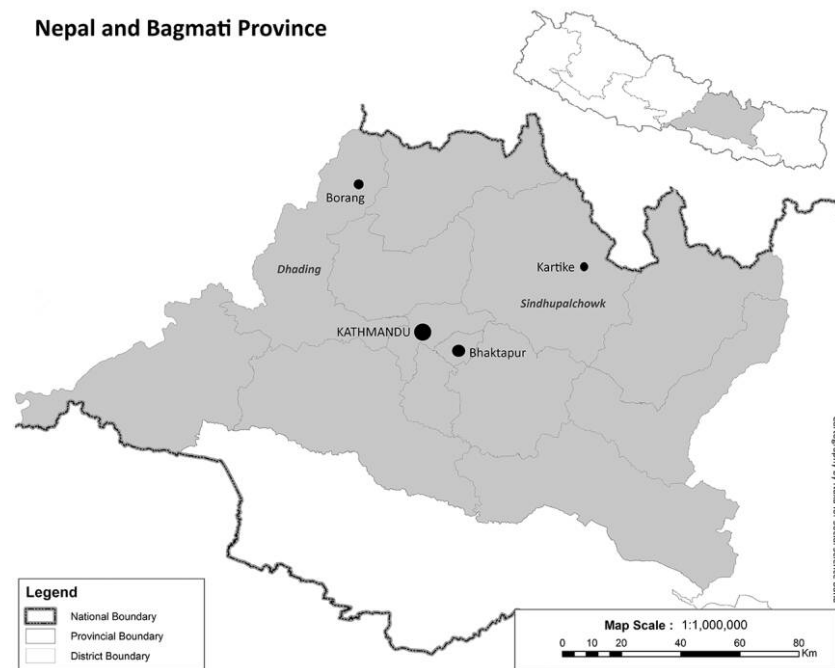


Figure 3. Map of research sites. Cartography by Naxa for Social Science Baha.

Technology–Nepal (NSET–Nepal), a Nepali NGO.⁸ In Sindhupalchowk, the research site was Kartike Bazaar and the adjoining villages of Manje and Golche (fig. 5). Kartike is a small market town with road access amid an otherwise rural area and was also chosen to understand dynamics in a setting where the Baliyo Ghar program was not implemented. Material from these areas is complemented by long-term, ongoing ethnographic research in Dolakha district (Shneiderman 2015b).

Research was conducted in three phases. From March to May 2018, the team primarily conducted interviews with individuals at the household level. From September 2018 to January 2019, the focus was on key local institutions and individuals as well as government agencies and other relevant organizations. Additional interviews with national-level organizations in Kathmandu took place from mid-2019 to early 2020, along with a follow-up visit to Dhading district. In total, we conducted formal and informal interviews with more than 180 individuals and observed interactions in and around the district headquarters, mainly in banks and around public infrastructure (police stations, road construction projects, local schools, hydropower projects, etc.) and cultural heritage sites under reconstruction. Interviews were conducted in Nepali and translated into English.

Nepal's earthquakes struck at a period of protracted political impasse. Despite two Constituent Assembly elections follow-

ing the 2006 Comprehensive Peace Agreement, the postconflict constitution-making process was still incomplete when the earthquakes struck in 2015. This long delay was largely due to conflicts over the demarcation of new federal and local administrative boundaries. Desire to access pending funds pledged during the International Conference on Nepal's Reconstruction in June 2015 led the major parties to "fast-track" the constitution (Liechty and Hutt 2021; Paudel and Le Billon 2018). A constitution was finally promulgated on September 20, 2015, followed by several months of protest, especially along the eastern Terai bordering India. Protestors cited several regressive provisions in the constitution over new subnational boundaries and their associated administrative apparatus. These political contestations disrupted trade flows, including essential imports from India, but also delayed the establishment of the NRA until December 2015.⁹

Based on the government's Post Disaster Needs Assessment, the NRA promised grants of NPR 300,000 for each fully damaged house,¹⁰ broken into three installments, or "tranches." However, highly bureaucratic processes to assess needs, verify claims, disburse funds, and confirm compliance at each stage of construction complicated access. At the time of publication, over one million households had been surveyed, with 866,207

8. With core funding support from the US Agency for International Development (USAID), Baliyo Ghar was implemented in four districts (Kathmandu, Dolakha, Dhading, and Nuwakot) over a five-year period. See <http://www.nset.org.np/nset2012/index.php/programs/programdetail/programid-93>.

9. The NRA's mandate expired in December 2021 after this article was accepted. It was succeeded by the National Disaster Risk Reduction Management Authority (NDRRMA).

10. The program was first announced with NPR 200,000 per household, which was later revised upward in September 2016. Partially damaged houses were eligible to apply for retrofit grants of NPR 100,000 in two installments.



Figure 4. Two sisters-in-law look out of windows from their conjoined but differently reconstructed properties, Bhaktapur, 2018. Photo: Sara Shneiderman.

households verified as eligible “beneficiaries” for private housing reconstruction grants, but only 653,467 had actually completed constructing houses—approximately 75%.¹¹

Although the NRA was a federal government agency, it was funded by donors, who maintained significant influence throughout the process.¹² In this sense, reconstruction can be understood as an extension of long-standing national and international interventions and approached through analytical frameworks that emphasize how subjectivities are transformed through the discourses and practices of development in Nepal (Fujikura 2023; Gyawali 2018; Pigg 1992).

Increasingly, scholars studying infrastructure and development in Nepal have described aspects of their confluence as processually experienced, including through financialization (Le Billon et al. 2020; Paudel, Rankin, and Le Billon 2020) and through their mediation of international relations with China and India, in a dynamic that Murton (2020) terms “infrastructural relationality.” The political opportunities—and pressures—engendered by such relationalities must be understood not only vis-à-vis external actors but as an internal logic of the developmentalist Nepali state used to enroll citizens and compel compliance. The fact that the disaster occurred at a moment of postconflict political transition meant that devolution of key service provisions to new provincial and local

governing bodies occurred contemporaneously with reconstruction. While, on the one hand, this offered new prospects for long-desired local governance to emerge in practice, creating political opportunities for newly elected officials to demonstrate their power by controlling access to reconstruction funds, on the other hand, it also put officials at all levels under pressure to demonstrate accountability. As we will show below, much of this burden was passed on to individual citizens through the categorical imperatives of eligibility through rigid definitions of house and household.

Preearthquake Houses

Houses across Nepal were not uniform before the 2015 earthquakes. To the contrary, each structure was unique in its materials and design, as most residences were constructed by their inhabitants rather than professional builders or contractors. While houses within a given settlement may have borne common characteristics denoting shared ethnic, class, and regional identities, they were also shaped by the idiosyncrasies of family preferences and animated by interactions between the many people who lived in them—the members of their households. Earlier anthropological scholarship about Nepal often identified house styles with particular ethnic communities; for instance, Tom Fricke (1993 [1986]:38) writes of “the Tamang House,” while Toffin, Barré, and Berger (2016 [1991]:115) describe “the traditional Newar house” as a “highly distinctive dwelling.” While our research was not focused on specific ethnic communities per se, we concur with these scholars that house building has historically been an important material practice through which communities assert identity

11. <http://www.nra.gov.np/en> (accessed July 23, 2023).

12. Direct engagement in NRA planning processes was confirmed in an interview with Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA) officials in February 2020; this is also evident in projects like Baliyo Ghar funded by USAID and the World Bank–funded Earthquake Housing Reconstruction Project previously mentioned.



Figure 5. Houses with shop fronts in Kartike Bazaar, 2018. Photo: Manoj Suji.

and belonging.¹³ Indeed, it is these particularities that were often collapsed into singular form through the constraints of the reconstruction program. In this section we hope to evoke some sense of the affective experience one might have had on entering houses as they stood in each site before their seismic destruction in 2015. In order to facilitate analysis and preserve anonymity, the short descriptive vignettes that follow focus on general characteristics of houses in each locale.

For many communities in Nepal, houses served as a microcosm of cosmology and conceptions of kinship. This was the case in Borang, Dhading. Residents typically constructed southern-facing houses of stones, mud, and mortar.¹⁴ Upon entering the house, on the farthest corner, a kitchen usually housed the chulo (wood-burning hearth inset in the floor or wall). The dining area and kitchen were usually in the same room, with family members congregating to eat just a few feet away from the chulo. The main deity of the house and its family was usually enshrined in one of the other corners. If a member of the family left to build their own house, the new space usually would not have its own deity, as despite the separate material structure, in social terms the new house-family was considered rhizomatically as an extension of the

main abode (*mul ghar*).¹⁵ The styles and materials of houses in Borang have evolved over the years to include two- to three-story houses, with roofing of slate tiles from a local quarry or, more recently, metal CGI (corrugated galvanized iron) sheets. Firewood might be stored on the ground floor, with living quarters above.¹⁶

In Kartike Bazaar, Sindhupalchowk, residents constructed their houses to serve the dual function of living quarters and places of business for their small, bustling bazaar town. Before the earthquake, most people had houses made of stone, wood, and mud, while a few had concrete or thatched-roof houses. Most houses were two stories or higher so that families would have enough space for running their economic enterprises as well as space for living, cooking, and storing food grains and other belongings. The types of businesses found on the ground floor of a multistoried house included general stores, grocery stores, and small restaurants. Some residents utilized these spaces to house farming equipment, sell homemade alcohol, or arrange wage labor. The houses were built in rows along the main road that ran through the bazaar, each adjoining the next. Some families had small outhouses or fields just behind

13. Together, our vignettes and field material describe Newar, Tamang, and to a lesser extent Brahmin, Chhetri, Dalit, and Thangmi houses and households.

14. Fricke (1993 [1986]:38–39) provides further details of “the Tamang house” in Tipling, a village adjacent to Borang. Actual Tamang building styles varied significantly even between neighboring villages, both before and after the earthquake.

15. First appropriated by Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari (1987) as a mental image for philosophical speculation, a rhizome is a dendrological subterranean root system where axillary buds develop horizontally and send up shoots from nodes, which if separated can grow into an independent plant. The image has been used countless times in social science to depict connections between semiotic chains, power structures, and relative circumstances.

16. Here livestock were not typically housed on the ground floor, as is common in some Himalayan communities.

their houses, but many also maintained a homestead in one of the surrounding villages where they worked their agricultural land on a part-time basis.

Thus far, we have considered village houses and houses in regional market towns, but what about the dense urban environment of the Kathmandu valley? Before the earthquake, houses in the town of Bhaktapur were suffused with iconic local design elements, such as wood-frame windows and doors carved by a specially trained group of hereditary artisans, roofs of clay *jhingati* tiles, and walls built with *dachhi-appa* (traditional bricks). Many ethnographic accounts (Levy 1991; Nepali 1965; Toffin 2007, 2016 [1991]) have explained the physical characteristics and sociocultural values of Newar houses, which helps us trace their material and cultural significance prior to the 2015 earthquakes. Bhaktapur had many reinforced-concrete houses built vertically on very small plots of land, stretching three, four, even five stories high according to traditional architectural designs. In Newar tradition, house design was associated with practices of purity and pollution (Levy 1991). Yet in a fashion similar to Kartike Bazaar, residents also used the ground floor of houses in Bhaktapur for small stores, while the middle floors were used as sleeping rooms for family and guests. Most Newar feasts and rituals took place on the top floors because people from lower-caste families were not allowed on the top floor, where the kitchen was located (Nepali 1965).

Unlike the houses in Borang, where the arrangement of interior space was the defining characteristic, the inside of a house in Bhaktapur resembled any other building in densely populated areas of the Kathmandu valley. The individuality of interior choices reflects the urban middle-class lifestyle of Bhaktapur residents as much as the lack of guidance in either national building codes or municipal bylaws regarding the inside of homes. Instead, these houses were defined by their externally visible representations of cultural heritage through specific building materials and forms of artisanship (fig. 6).

The distinctive features of Bhaktapur houses, and the fact that postearthquake regulation focused only on their exterior appearance, bring into relief key issues when considered in comparison to our other field sites. The house is metonymized by its exterior from the perspective of policymakers, while the home indexes the interiority of the structure from the affective perspectives of those who live in it. The contrast between the top-down concern for the aesthetics of rebuilding Bhaktapur as a UNESCO World Heritage Site, and the lack thereof in our other field sites, highlights a broader disparity between reconstruction in rural areas, where functionality was emphasized, and reconstruction in urban heritage areas where aesthetics were also seen as important. This discrepancy has reinscribed rural/urban divides in Nepal, just at the moment that the administrative restructuring of 2017 incorporated many hitherto “village development committees” into new “municipalities” or “rural municipalities” (Ruszczuk 2020). The contrasting experiences across our field sites revealed such underlying dynamics in a way that would have been difficult to observe from a single site alone.



Figure 6. Artisan carving wooden windows in Bhaktapur, 2018. Photo: Bina Limbu.

While specific requirements for reconstruction may have differed by location, houses acted as infrastructural mediators between state policies and citizen practices across our field sites. This assertion builds on insights from feminist geography, which clarifies that the “social reproduction of the material bases of society involves not only the large-scale physical infrastructure of capitalism . . . but the small-scale social, physical, cultural and emotional infrastructure of the household” (Marston 2000:233). Even before the 2015 earthquakes, houses in all of our sites could be understood as both infrastructure and process, produced through the continual labor of maintenance (Besky 2017), rather than as fixed and unchanging entities.

For example, over the past 25 years in Dolakha, a rural district just east of Sindhupalchowk, we have observed houses that experienced multiple renovations long before the 2015 earthquakes. These included shifts from slate or thatch roofing to CGI metal roofing; expansions from one- to two- or occasionally even three-story houses; reconfigurations of internal space driven by electrification and other innovations like smokeless cookstoves, as well as by shifts in kinship structure due to births, marriages, deaths, or migration; and updates to exterior finishings such as glass windows, metal window grates, and wooden doors. Many such material improvements were funded by remittance income earned by household members living far away from the physical house. A man in

Dhading told us how he had spent 17 years working in Kuwait in order to earn enough money to renovate his ancestral home to the tune of NPR 10,000,000—work he had completed just months before the building was destroyed by the earthquake. These details help us understand why the one-size-fits-all notion of a house that undergirded the NRA's reconstruction program could not approximate the long-term labors of care and individual expression that many houses instantiated in their predisaster form.

This section has set the scene by describing the material and affective experience of the house in our field sites. In sum, houses had different defining features before the earthquake, related to the livelihood strategies, kinship structures, cosmologies, and material resources of the families who inhabited them. Indeed, these are enduring themes in the anthropology of Nepal, as well as within broader anthropological frameworks, which the following section explores in greater depth.

Anthropological Frameworks

The House as a Unit of Sociality

Previous anthropological approaches to the house have often treated it as either a metaphor for kinship (Bourdieu 1990; Lévi-Strauss 1982 [1979]) or as a container for the socialities and material cultures that live within its walls (Miller 2001), rather than as a site for anthropological analysis in its own material form. Along these lines, Carsten and Hugh-Jones (1995:3) argue that the house is so ubiquitous across cultures that it has often been rendered invisible to ethnographers, who instead become preoccupied with the daily interactions of people living within the house—focusing on either kinship relations or material culture found inside its walls.

One perspective on the house prevalent in Himalayan anthropology renders it as an ecological interface between so-called man and his environment (Toffin 2016 [1991]). Houses are presented as a crucial element of sociocultural life but in an essentialized manner that casts the house as a static mediator between the human and natural worlds. For example, John Gray (2006) suggests that houses substitute for the natural world in the tantric Hindu cosmology of Kholagaun Chhetris. Ritual specialists use astrology and geomancy of the lifeworld of householders and their cosmos to intimately link architecture, activities, and ritual performances via material construction, auspicious times and places, and the consubstantiality of the house and its owner. These are considered refractions of each other, so that the house becomes an auspicious place for domestic activities (Gray 2006:70). Similarly, Fricke (1993 [1986]) describes how “an ideal Tamang home exists in people's minds,” yet he also recognizes that “only a few approach this ideal” (38).

We build on these insights in recognizing the central role that houses play in shaping identity in rural Nepal but depart from them in two key ways. First of all, we suggest that houses interact with processes of individual and collective self-conception in a processual and fluid manner, in addition to

acting as important points of fixity in what are often disaggregated and mobile livelihood schemes. In this we expand on Sarah Besky's (2017) recent analysis of the house as a site of fixity in Darjeeling, by suggesting that it is not a matter of fluidity in opposition to fixity but both at once—perhaps in variegated ways for different families and individuals. In other words, houses may be understood as both infrastructure and process and as a means of understanding infrastructure as process. Second of all, we demonstrate how houses mediate not only between people and their environment but also between people and their systems of governance. In our ethnography of postearthquake residential reconstruction, a consideration of the house as a material structure in relation to the household as a social structure reveals a complex understanding of the modes of ownership and belonging that constitute the home. These are mutually comprised of a shifting set of relationships between territory, built forms, families, individuals, and multiple layers of the state, as well as other agents of governance such as I/NGOs.

By working with a tripartite schema of house, household, and home, we draw from and expand on existing anthropological literature that has proposed various bipartite distinctions between house and home. In some previous scholarship, authors have attempted to distinguish between houses as units of sociality versus units of materiality through, for example, the “social house” versus the “architectural house” (Vellinga 2007), or between houses as social institutions (often conflated with the household) and homes as units of belonging in a broad, subjective sense (Samanani and Lenhard 2019). Other literature has focused on homeowners as actors who through identity and lifestyle (Lawrence-Zúñiga 2010) produce value and aesthetics (Lawrence-Zúñiga 2015). There is potential for a rich comparison with the anthropology of Southeast Asian houses, which has previously highlighted the interrelation between materiality and kinship (Carsten 2018; Sparkes and Howell 2003) and their links to concerns over inheritance (Lien and Abram 2018). Finally, we draw on previous work that has shown how local conceptions of households can shape spatial, temporal, and financial claims of belonging and responsibility for both homeowners and the state (DeLuca 2017).

The Household as a Unit of Production

As Geoff Childs and Namgyal Choedup (2018) note in their recent book on education, migration, and social change in Himalayan Nepal, “the household continues to be an important unit of analysis in anthropology, yet it is not always carefully defined” (43). Following Michael Chibnik (2011), Childs and Choedup trace how for much of the twentieth century, the household was considered an irrelevant unit of social analysis. Early anthropologists instead prioritized the kinship-related notion of “house” as lineage. It was only in conversation with economists in the 1970s that the household emerged as a sufficiently universal and recognizable unit for cross-cultural and historical comparison, particularly for those engaged in

demography and cultural ecology. The concept perhaps reached its pinnacle with the publication of Marshall Sahlins's (2017 [1972]) *Stone Age Economics*. For Sahlins, the household is the primary economic unit of production, centered on its ability to control labor (69). Yet Sahlins also recognizes the fluidity of the concept: "I do not suggest that the household everywhere is an exclusive work group, and production merely a domestic activity . . . members of one family may regularly collaborate on an individual basis with kith and kin from other houses" (70). Here we see the slippage between the concepts of household and house—with the latter carrying the double entendre of both lineage and physical structure of residence.

While the concept of the household remained contested within anthropology (Wilk 1991:1), it became ever more commonly deployed within the expanding field of international development. Fricke implies that work like his own that situates the household within specific ethnographic contexts, rather than positing it as a universal, is a much-needed corrective to the positivist use of the concept in development policy (Fricke 1993 [1986]). In a 1991 paper directed at development practitioners and policymakers, Naila Kabeer (1991) articulates this position explicitly, in a feminist critique of what she calls the "neo-classical economic household" (1). Nonetheless, 20 years later, Michael Chibnik (2011) still found it necessary to state that "although anthropologists have written extensively about problems in defining and delineating 'households,' economists for the most part seem unconcerned about these issues" (118).

Despite the ongoing anthropological debate about the challenges of defining the household as either an economic or social unit, by the second half of the twentieth century it had become one of the core operating principles of the international development industry. Through donor engagement with Nepal's National Planning Commission (NPC), Central Bureau of Statistics (CBS), and other government agencies, many such social scientific concepts became uncritically embedded within the country's planning and governance infrastructure (Campbell, Shrestha, and Stone 2010 [1979]). As our empirical material below shows, the disaster of 2015 revealed the normative limitations of the household as both a unit of analysis and one of aid disbursement.

The Home as a Unit of Belonging, Identity Production, and Dwelling

In contrast to the household, conceptualized primarily as a unit of production, in the social sciences, the home has been understood as a site of identity production, where those who dwell express their affective belonging to that particular place. Phenomenological anthropology draws upon Heidegger, for whom the place where one dwells is concomitant with feeling one has a place in the world, a home. The human subject is formed through sense-making practices and familiar exterior structures (Heidegger 2005; Ingold 2000). However, dwelling does not necessarily presuppose sedentary life. Even before international labor migration became common, for instance,

Tamang language speakers in the high mountain valleys of Nepal occupied their houses only during ceremonial times of the year. The rest of the time, peripatetic herders dwelled in mobile shelters between field and pasture locations outside of village geography (Campbell 1993).

Just as dwelling does not presuppose sedentary life, mobile life does not presuppose a lack of dwelling. While phenomenological approaches to understanding attachment to place through concepts like topophilia (Tuan 1990), or being "at home in the world" (Jackson 1995), are valuable for understanding belonging in relation to land itself in contexts of high mobility, we must also recognize the power of houses to mediate that relationship to land, as well as relationships to government and between members of a household. As Amy Johnson (2020:216) explains through her ethnography of mobile families in the Kailali region of Far Western Nepal, it is in fact the practices of housework, or *ghar ko kaam*, that reproduce belonging and sustain households under persistent conditions of *basai-sarai*—"residence shift"—a term that captures the mundane patterns of mobility that characterize many Nepali livelihoods.

The distinction between house and home has been revisited in a range of recent ethnographic contexts, including in relation to postdisaster reconstruction elsewhere. For example, Barrios (2014) notes how in the aftermath of Hurricane Mitch in Honduras, many beneficiaries of government and NGO-sponsored reconstruction "refused to recognize the structures as homes, repeatedly referring to them as shoebox or matchbox houses" (337). This was due in part to structural faults but also because the houses were constructed on small parcels of land that "could not accommodate growing families" (337). Such sentiments are echoed in the term *bhukampa ghar* (earthquake house), as described at the beginning of this article, as well as in the term *sarkar ko ghar* (government's house), that we shall encounter below.

Indeed, the difference between the material structure of a house and the site of belonging embodied in a home may lie in the affective labor required to produce the latter through maintenance over time (Besky 2017). Such maintenance may include investment in the physical structure of the building, but this is oriented toward "turning a house into a fixed space of intergenerational belonging" through making it "a suitable space for welcoming extended families during festivals" (Besky 2017:626). It is indeed this long-term work that many earthquake-affected families in Nepal are now embarking on—and where they see limitations in the houses that they have built through the reconstruction program.

Policy Frameworks and Their Implementation in Postearthquake Nepal

Defining "the Household"

According to the Nepal Living Standard Survey 2010–2011, the country's Central Bureau of Statistics has adopted a

definition of “household” based on United Nations guidelines (UN 2008). These define a household as “arrangements made by persons, individually or in groups, for providing themselves with food or other essentials for living” (CBS 2011). A household may consist of one or more persons who may be related or unrelated and may have a common budget. The same definition of household is employed in the Population Monograph of Nepal 2014, Annual Household Survey 2014–2015, and Nepal Labour Force Survey 2008. The latter further clarifies that two factors must be present to produce a household: dwelling under one roof and eating together. Neither one on its own is sufficient: “People who live in the same dwelling, but do not share food expenses or eat meals together, are not members of the same household . . . Likewise, people who eat together but do not live in the same dwelling are not members of the same household” (CBS 2009). The 2003 Population Monograph further informs us that “this definition of household has been used in population censuses of the country since 1952/54” (Kayastha and Shrestha 2003).

This long-operative definition of the household based on separated kitchen or cooking space matches with Nepali conceptualizations of the household in lived experience, as expressed in the term *chulo*, which literally means “hearth.” Roughly synonymous to *chulo* is the term *bhancha*, or “kitchen.” The terms *chulo* or *bhancha chuteko* (separated kitchen) were commonly used across all of our field sites to designate a separate household unit in practice: a group of people, related or unrelated, who both dwell and eat together. However, our interlocutors also understood that not all *chulo* are *gharduri*, the formal term for a legally registered household. These differences significantly affected flows of postdisaster resources.

The very first relief payments of NPR 100,000 were provided to households who lost a family member in the earthquake, followed by NPR 30,000 for funeral rites. Then, cash grants of NPR 15,000 for temporary shelters¹⁷ and NPR 10,000 for winterization relief (targeted to vulnerable groups) were provided to “earthquake victims” identified in the initial damage assessments, with priority given to “red-card” holders with “fully damaged” houses (TAF 2016).¹⁸ Due to widespread complaints about inconsistencies, an NRA-led CBS survey reassessed damaged houses in 2016 to identify beneficiaries for private housing reconstruction and retrofitting grants. Soon thereafter, ideas of the household came into play when beneficiary cards were issued to a single *gharmuli* (household head) for the

entire beneficiary family. The 2015 Post Disaster Needs Assessment did not offer a clear definition of household, stating only, “the total number of houses to be reconstructed has been calculated on the basis of [the] number of households made homeless” (NPC 2015).

These definitional ambiguities became challenges in lived reality for many of the participants in our research. For instance, in Bhaktapur, we documented multiple household units—or *chulo*—living in the same house, understood in terms of the physical structure. Usually, these units were comprised of brothers living together with their families in different stories/apartments or rooms of their father’s or grandfather’s house. Many of these families cooked in separate kitchens. If we abide by the legal definitions above, these families should be considered as separate households despite living under the same roof. However, the ownership of such families over the house property was not initially recognized in many cases. This was because residents had not transferred ownership from their fathers or grandfathers into the current generation’s names, a process that would have enabled recognition of the multiple *chulo*, converting each of these to *gharduri*. In most of these families, property had not been partitioned for two generations or more.¹⁹

Defining “the House”

Meanwhile, Nepal’s Central Bureau of Statistics defines “house ownership” as the legal status of owning a house or part of a house or apartment used by the household (Kayastha and Shrestha 2003). Yet it is made clear that “there is no standard definition of residential house, ownership of house and its type in the country” and that “this causes problems in comparing data obtained from different sources” (175). Minimally, a “house refers to a structure where [a] household is using it as a shelter and which is closed or surrounded by walls or curtains made of many types of materials such as mud, wood planks, bricks, stone, concrete, etc. A house may contain any number of rooms, but it must have a separate way to get inside. It is noted here that a house may have contained more than one household” (175).

Despite, or perhaps because of, the well-known issues with these definitions, the NRA issued vague guidelines at the federal level that confused beneficiaries, as well as its line agencies responsible for managing the process of grant access (TAF

17. Cash grants for temporary shelters were NPR 15,000 for households in the “fully damaged” category, and NPR 3000 for those in the “partially damaged” category.

18. First, rapid assessments were done by local administrative units (village development committees or municipalities) to guide initial relief efforts. Then, a detailed damage assessment led by engineers was conducted by the relevant District Disaster Relief Committee, which categorized victims according to fully damaged, partially damaged, and normal/undamaged houses, represented by red, green, and yellow cards, respectively.

19. It was only after Nepal’s 1964 Land Reform Act that Nepal moved toward a legal definition of property ownership based on liberal individualistic ideals, and it became advisable to partition land between brothers or across generations (Kunreuther 2009). Previously there had been no pressing reason to legally validate customary use. Due to uneven implementation and continuing localized practices of customary law, in many parts of the country, families had not seen the need to partition property until the postearthquake reconstruction regime required them to do so. See also Haxby (2017).

2016). Likewise, the criteria for beneficiary households introduced in late 2015 were not based on the separation of cooking space but rather the preearthquake existence of physical structures. Questions arose about who owned the land on which the house sat and who was legally entitled to rebuild each structure.

These questions diverted the focus from the full kinship unit of the household(s) living in each house to individuals with the legal claim to property ownership. NRA guidelines stipulated that beneficiaries needed legal certificates of land ownership (*dhanipurja* or *lalpurja*) predating the earthquakes to be eligible for housing reconstruction grants (NRA 2015). Only these individuals were recognized as formal beneficiaries who could sign a participation agreement for a housing reconstruction grant with the government (fig. 7). Those households who had not partitioned their house property but had been living separately before the earthquake were also eligible, but conditions applied. They first needed to confirm their separated status through a public inquiry, then partition their share of land and gain legal ownership certificates for it (NRA 2015). Such criteria that relied on formally documented land ownership to define house ownership made grant access difficult for many people whose houses had been destroyed. No legal distinction was made between house ownership and land ownership; in other words, even if a family had built a house with their own resources by mutual agreement on land for-

mally registered to someone else, there was no straightforward way for them to claim ownership over the house for the purposes of reconstruction without also partitioning the land.²⁰

This, in turn, had the effect of limiting the definition of citizenship—in the sense of the right to make claims on the state—to those who were legally recognized as landowners. Such a definition could not accommodate the experience of cross-border citizenship and belonging common for many Nepalis (Shneiderman 2013), which, as Nadine Plachta (2020) explains in reference to residents of the Lapchi region of Dolakha district, “fostered practices and opportunities for local agency that were the basis for demands for post-earthquake support and protection” (148). It also reinforced in tautological fashion the gendered citizenship regime of the Nepali state (Grossman-Thompson and Dennis 2017), which made it difficult for many women to access citizenship, let alone land ownership, the lack of which made it impossible for many to exercise their rights to make claims on the state as beneficiaries of the reconstruction program. Finally, it elided the messy relations of kinship, caste, ethnicity, and mobility, which often left those responsible for the upkeep of fields and private housing infrastructure without legal ownership.

Reconstruction guidelines therefore reified the notion of *gharduri* as the only legally recognizable form of household by linking it in a one-on-one manner to the individual physical unit of the house and, further, to the land on which it sat. Donor organizations as well as the government promoted this strategy, believing that restricting eligibility to a clearly defined *gharmuli* (household head) would enhance accountability and create a natural cap on the number of eligible households.²¹ They sought to limit the number of beneficiaries from expanding beyond those initially identified by the District Disaster Relief Committees and to protect the implementing agencies from additional financial and political risk at the moment of devolution from federal to provincial and local governments that occurred contemporaneously with reconstruction. As Mukta S. Tamang and colleagues (2020) write in a USAID-funded study, “the centralized structure of eligible beneficiary identification may have been the safest and the easiest way for the government . . . but it also engendered doubts about the process among the population” (79).

The guidelines therefore had difficulty accommodating the ground reality of multiple household units that were living together in one house—as is common in urban areas—or, conversely, as is often the case in rural areas, single households spread across multiple housing units. In the case of compact urban settlements like Bhaktapur, people were at a disadvantage because multiple households were living under one roof, but they were not eligible for separate reconstruction grants. By contrast, in rural areas such as Sindhupalchowk and Dhading, multiple family members were able to apply for the grants



Figure 7. Applicants check their names on a list of approved beneficiaries, Dhading, 2018. Photo: Nabin Rawal.

20. On land tenure in Nepal, see Regmi (1976).

21. Interview with JICA officials, February 2020.

by showing that they were living separately in different houses before the earthquake—but only when their land title deeds matched their actual pattern of residence, which was often not the case.

A different definition of households as taxable units can be found in the House and Land Revenue Tax Act 2019 (NLC 1962 [VS 2019]). The taxation criterion distinguishes individuals owning different stories or parts of the same house as separate taxable units. At the same time, it clarifies that even if an individual owner has multiple houses in different areas, it is considered as one taxable unit. If similar criteria were applied to define households in terms of reconstruction, it may have captured both the situation of multiple households living under one roof in Bhaktapur and the situation of one household owning multiple houses units in rural Dhading and Sindhupalchowk.

However, the more limited definitions of “household” and “house” actually deployed in reconstruction have created a range of complications for affected people. Further, these definitions have in many cases led to restructuring of social relations, as our subsequent material shows.

Ethnographic Encounters: Reshaping Residential and Social Structures²²

How to Be a Household

In Bhaktapur, it was difficult to come to a consensus, as there were rampant family conflicts over the ownership of tiny plots of land. Even for joint-grant access, which was permitted through an amendment to the guidelines later in the process, people needed to obtain ownership documents by transferring the house property from the previous to successive generations.

Moreover, households with joint ownership were eligible for only one grant, provided that all parties could consensually nominate one representative among them as the grant recipient. If even one householder backed out, then everyone else would be ineligible for the grant. A man in Bhaktapur expressed his frustrations with this process:

I told him [my younger brother] that if we can come to an agreement with each other, we can get NPR 150,000 in the second tranche by showing the house design map of my new house. Out of that, I told him that I'd give NPR 50,000 to our mother, 50,000 to him, and keep 50,000 for myself. But he has not replied. Without his consent, we cannot take out the money.

Another Bhaktapur resident concurred, “Now, every brother owns a right over the house. The house is also very small, how do we divide it? Such problems exist among 60%–70% households here. That's why it is difficult to come to an agreement.” Although most common among brothers, such issues also

occurred between unrelated households inhabiting the same physical structure.²³

In rural contexts, people struggled with the converse problem, where one household was in many cases already spread across multiple houses or small *goth* (animal husbandry shelters) before the earthquakes. This situation was evident in Sindhupalchowk. According to the 2011 census, Pangtang had 487 households while Golche had 731. After the earthquake, about 777 households in Pangtang and 985 households in Golche were identified as grant beneficiaries.²⁴ The difference in these numbers is largely made up of households that were already separated into more than one chulo at the time of earthquake but as in the Bhaktapur cases described had not updated their land ownership papers. Before the earthquake, many families did not perceive it as necessary to transfer land ownership in order to legitimize additional physical structures built by different family members on their property. Indeed, it was considered unfilial to seek a share in the family property or partition it if older generations were still alive. At the level of practice, there was a clear distinction between house ownership and land ownership, but this was not reflected in the legal realities.

In order for a familial unit who had separated from their parents to formally transition from chulo to gharduri, enabling that unit to receive its own beneficiary card, a public inquiry was required. Before the 2017 election of local governments, this process was handled by the Village Development Committee (VDC) and afterward by the elected ward officials within the newly constituted municipality or rural municipality. An application had to be filed in person at the VDC level and reviewed at the District Development Committee level, with seven witnesses who themselves possessed a beneficiary card in the same ward supporting the claim. This was to ensure that the immediate community members confirmed that this particular residential unit deserved to be recognized as a gharduri on its own terms and to prevent absentee householders from commandeering resources. However, in many cases political party affiliation and personal networks played a role in this process: in our Sindhupalchowk field site, a ward chairperson as well as NRA field engineers told us that multiple family members of the same household were able to secure beneficiary cards due to their connections to the ruling party.

23. The emphasis on brothers is unavoidable, as *ghar* is an inherently gendered concept—the structure that houses a man's lineage—while *maita* is the term a woman uses to refer to her natal home (Kunreuther 2009:551). By norm, sons are entitled to inherit property from their fathers. A wife can inherit her husband's property; however, we found cases where widows were unfairly denied access. Most of our female interlocutors did not own property, except in the cases of widows who had inherited from their husbands.

24. National Reconstruction Authority, beneficiary enrolment for private housing reconstruction grant distribution in Sindhupalchowk data, April 24–July 8, 2016.

22. See working papers by Limbu et al. (2019b, 2022), Rawal et al. (2021), and Suji et al. (2020) for additional ethnographic context.

The rise in household numbers was critiqued in the Nepali press, as well as by donors, as relief transitioned into a formal reconstruction program (for a summary and rebuttal see Parajuli 2016). For instance, in a case from Dolakha, the NGO charged with implementing relief in one locality responded to the proliferation of new chulo by limiting the number of household units to which they would offer resources. That move was met by a collective community complaint to the VDC secretary, which was ultimately successful in securing equal resources for the full number of households, including newly registered chulo. These details suggest a community critique that echoes long-standing scholarly critiques of the neoclassical household model (Kabeer 1991)—as residents self-consciously sought to define what a household should be in administrative terms for the purposes of securing resources. By reconstituting kinship relations and the residential patterns with which they were linked, people found a way to shape their experience as recipients of aid. Such moves can be understood as expressions of agency in the face of hardship rather than through the trope of false victims.

Producing a House

Having signed participation agreements to enroll in the reconstruction program, families then struggled with how to build a physical structure in keeping with the approved building codes for “earthquake-resistant building.”²⁵ The material challenges of producing a house that complied with regulatory requirements brings into view relationships between citizens and a wide range of government agencies.

The Department of Urban Development and Building Construction (DUDBC) published a building catalog focusing on rural housing reconstruction in October 2015, which was subsequently adopted by the NRA. Four main types of house designs were promoted: stone and mud mortar masonry, brick and mud mortar masonry, stone and cement mortar masonry, and brick and cement mortar masonry (DUDBC 2015). Volume II of the catalog was published only in March 2017, with 17 house designs to support both rural and urban reconstruction (DUDBC 2017). People in rural areas faced particularly acute problems since the house designs and materials were not in line with their needs and available resources. According to the project director of the Central Level Project Implementation Unit at DUDBC, the second volume of the catalog was a revised version that considered alternative construction materials and people’s cultural needs. Later, in mid-2017, the NRA also published *Corrections/Exception Manual for Masonry Structures* (NRA 2017a) and *Repair and Retrofitting Manual for Masonry Structures* (NRA 2017b), which addressed many problems of noncompliance, enabling additional houses to qualify for further housing grants.

25. Terms categorized by DUDBC (<http://www.dudbc.gov.np/buildingcode>).

However, even after revised house designs for urban reconstruction were introduced, the reconstruction process in Bhaktapur did not speed up. There, people had to follow both the government’s building codes for earthquake-resistant homes and a second set of heritage codes stipulated in bylaws promulgated by the municipality and the federal Department of Archaeology, which required houses within the heritage area of Bhaktapur to follow traditional Newar designs.²⁶ Many people found this to be impractical, especially the criteria for a *jhingati* tile roof with a 25–30° slope and building height limitations of 10.6 m (8.5 m if a heritage monument was nearby). People understood that any house that did not abide by these codes would not receive the formal House Construction Completion Certificate. Without this, the house could not be used as an asset for future banking or real estate transactions.

As one Bhaktapur resident explained:

Nobody can make the kind of house that they [government officials] want. They tell us to make our house in such and such structure with a certain type of roof. How can we do that?! On top of it, the price of materials is increasing everyday—people may or may not have that kind of money. If they have to sell half of their land to [raise enough money to] follow the guidelines, then where would they build the house?

Another interlocutor shared details about the tension between ideas of traditional lifestyles and modern realities as embodied in the material design of the house:

[According to the heritage codes] the height should be 35 feet for a three-and-half-storied building, with a traditional style slope roof. But if we make the sloped roof, we will not have a place to put the water tank . . . To follow the standard, our lifestyles should be like in the past. Now, our daily life is not possible without a water tank on the roof which supplies the water for the toilet, bathroom, and kitchen. In the past, it was not needed because there was a public water tap . . . Although we are living in the heritage site areas, it is difficult to live our life as in the past.

In Dhading, we encountered a different set of issues. Soon after the earthquake, state presence was at a minimum, so people did not expect much support from the government. Despite the absence of government intervention, the disaster had already taught people that they needed to strengthen their houses. The most ingrained lesson in people’s minds was that the upper story should not be heavy, as it posed a risk of collapsing on them during the earthquake. Hence, people rejected their traditional style of stone houses and instead proceeded to with lighter materials like wood and CGI sheets for the upper stories.

People invested great time, effort, and money to repair their damaged houses. The cost was reported at NPR

26. Bhaktapur Nagarpalikako Bhautik Purwadhar tatha Nirman Mapanda Sambandhi Viniyam, 2060 (Physical Infrastructure and Construction Criteria Related Bylaws of Bhaktapur Municipality, 2004).

400,000–500,000, with some participants even reporting up to NPR 900,000 because of the increased cost of construction materials and transportation on mules or by human porters. Nevertheless, people were willing to spend money, as they felt ownership and belonging in these houses. Foreign remittances also helped to finance these costs. However, there were also poor households who could not afford to make such structural changes and made only minor repairs (fig. 8). This was long before the reconstruction program was rolled out.

When the house design maps prescribed by the government entered northern Dhading through the National Society for Earthquake Technology (NSET) *Baliyo Ghar* (Strong House) program in late 2016, about 1.5 years after the earthquakes, another phase of reconstruction began. Many people were initially against building these *baliyo ghar*. An NSET official working in the rural municipality described the initial response that he faced: “At first, when we came to teach people, they got angry. They said things like, ‘This is my house; I will make it however I want. It’s no business of yours. Your organization gives you your salary, so get going on your way.’” Since most people were already living in repaired old houses, they felt no immediate need to build an additional new house. Moreover, within the NPR 300,000 budget envelope, it was very difficult for people to build more than a one-roomed house compliant with the building codes. However, as people began to understand what was on offer, attitudes began to shift. Participants described how their motivation increased after they understood that building a separate one-roomed house would provide access to funds.

Further, there were a range of rumors about the consequences of not enrolling or failing to complete reconstruction,

which scared people into compliance. These included rumors that the first tranche might need to be returned, that land ownership certificates would be seized, and that children might be barred from receiving birth certificates and citizenship documents.

Amid these rumors, some people also believed that the new government-designed houses might actually be a stronger alternative. Although they might not withstand big earthquakes, at least residents might have enough time to flee. Here we can see a material tension between official definitions of a “real house”—which often produced unlivable but technically resilient structures—and residents’ definitions of a “real house” in the lived terms of home, which we take up in the next subsection.

Becoming Home?

At first, many householders did not feel true ownership, in the sense of belonging, nor were they actually dwelling in the new structures built to code. The new buildings served various purposes, but they did not replace the homes that had been lost. Prodded with rumors, incentives, and some hopes of future safety, Dhading residents began to build houses as per the government standards—often in addition to their already repaired, previously standing house. This led to the rise of one-roomed houses in the NSET program area, based on the stonemasonry design included among the 17 design models in the DUDBC catalogue (fig. 9). These houses complied with the regulations, were affordable within the grant amount, and were feasible to construct within the program’s tight deadlines. Building these houses cost about NPR 100,000–250,000 or more



Figure 8. An older man tends to his partially reconstructed home, Dhading, 2020. Photo: Sara Shneiderman.



Figure 9. National Reconstruction Authority office in Dhading, with reconstruction guidelines on the walls and grant application forms in boxes on the floor. Photo: Sara Shneiderman.

(depending on the stones and wood resources that people owned). After reconstruction expenses, people were usually left with some small balance.

The reconstruction program reached our Sindhupalchowk field site earlier due to its relative proximity to roads, so people had not yet rebuilt in the same way as in Dhading. Their relatively quick enrolment in the reconstruction program led to a different set of challenges, as they built one-roomed houses under the supervision of engineers and technical advisors from various I/NGOs and the NRA. These initial houses were built under the belief that these were the only approved designs—only to learn later that there were advisory alternatives. Along with this misconception, the affordability and efficiency of these houses made them convenient to build. The NRA and associated I/NGOs were concerned with demonstrating a visible and quantifiable reconstruction output within their project timelines. In this process, the ethos of “owner-driven” reconstruction that intended to allow people to rebuild homes according to their own chosen design seems to have lost its essence. Later in Sindhupalchowk, correction manuals were circulated, and new designs for larger houses of up to two stories were introduced. Even the initially built one-roomed houses had to be retrofitted at the foundations. This trapped people in a seemingly unending cycle of building and rebuilding, which also led to conflicts between family members about disparate housing outcomes:

Nowadays, everyone is making two [to] three houses. First, they built one. Then, they made another one with DPC [approved foundation technique], so that it would be passed . . . If the house maps had arrived earlier, we wouldn't have to

build two [to] three houses. It was difficult for us. We had to rebuild again and again.

For all of these reasons, people seemed to lack a sense of ownership over these one-roomed houses. They called them *sarkar ko ghar* (the government's house) or *anudan ko ghar* (grant house).

Like in Dhading, most people in Sindhupalchowk felt that these houses would be somewhat stronger than preearthquake structures due to the wooden joints at every two-foot interval around the walls. Many participants said that it was the only major difference between the old and new houses. However, people were especially doubtful about the use of untreated raw wood in these bondages that were liable to rot when it rained. For them, the use of cement and iron rods would have made the houses more desirable, but people did not have the money to buy and transport such materials. Hence, the new houses were widely felt to be inadequate. Most people had plans to modify them by adding a story or extending the porch to make more space in the future, leading to our considerations below about what might make these grant houses into homes.

One of our interlocutors in Sindhupalchowk reflected:

The house is OK, but it is very small during the festival and ritual events when relatives visit us. We have only one sleeping room, and that is only enough for our own family.

And in Dhading:

People have many belongings such as big bamboo baskets, mats, and such, but there is no place to store them . . . When relatives come, where to make them sleep and where to sleep ourselves? The new house will only be good for a kitchen

room. Due to the wooden bondage, the house might not collapse, and it may be strong, but it is very small.

Likewise, a participant referred to living in such a situation as *bhedabakhra jastai hune*—living like goats and sheep.

Through plans to extend the existing one-room houses or engage in other forms of maintenance, it is possible that they will become homes yet. Much remains to be seen, and there is a wide range of opinions about the long-term impacts of the reconstruction experience on identity and belonging. For example, two members of the same community in Dhading held conflicting views about the long-term prospects of their house becoming a home. An older villager who had retired from the Nepal Army said:

What sort of cultural identity would this narrow one-roomed house reflect? It will instead ruin our culture . . . Once the reconstruction is completed, then they will realize that this house does not represent the identity of our community.

In contrast, a younger covillager in his mid-30s who ran a small timber provision and carpentry workshop suggested that

I think this house is fine. If I build my house in our traditional style, then maybe in the future our children may not like that house. They may say, 'I do not want to live in this type of house' and may run away from home.

These statements show how ideas of home, modernity, and belonging are under negotiation from various directions, with meaningful differences across generations and social locations. Experiences of mobility play a key role in framing such perspectives; feelings about what makes a house home are shaped by whether individuals actually live under the roof much of the time or return to it only for festival and other special occasions. Although people were happy to have some kind of housing, often it was felt to be inadequate, despite the exhausting and frustrating experience of working to comply with the regulations of the reconstruction program.

Conclusion

Through our ethnography of postearthquake private housing reconstruction in Nepal, this article has suggested a rapprochement between anthropological and policy paradigms in a tripartite framework that defines “house,” “household,” and “home” as distinctive concepts while also recognizing their interrelationship in practice. In anthropological terms, this might mean letting go of essentialist models of the house that emphasize either materiality or sociality, instead moving toward an understanding that they are both at once. Further, the household cannot be understood as coterminous with the physical structure of the house, let alone with ownership of the land on which it sits. The term remains useful as a unit of social and economic analysis but only to the extent that it can encompass mobility as a central feature of contemporary residence and kinship patterns.

Policymakers seeking to plan for private housing reconstruction after future disasters could productively consider their working definitions of these terms and the relationships between them during “disaster intervals” (Nihei 2012, as cited in Watanabe and Kimura 2018). Through community consultation, with reference to anthropological and other relevant social science literature, they might consider kinship arrangements, common culturally and regionally specific residential patterns, actual uses of domestic space, and existing relationships between physical structures for human habitation and ownership of the land on which they sit. Communicating information about these and other elements of recovery and reconstruction plans, policies, and guidelines, early and often (before, during, and after actual disaster) at the local level in language community members can understand would help avoid some of the ambivalent outcomes we observed in Nepal.

Our findings call into question the extent to which the reconstruction program in Nepal has in fact been owner driven. Rather, although legal land ownership was the criteria for determining eligibility for housing reconstruction grants, the limited definition of ownership and the constraints within which owners have had to produce a house recognized as legitimate by the authorities actually had the effect of weakening affective ownership and the ability of many people to dwell in their own home.

Further, we can see how the built form of the house itself mediates between family, government, and environment, materializing infrastructure as process. People’s relationships with their houses are fluid. For some, these reconstructed houses may come to serve as the conceptual anchor for mobile, shape-shifting households understood as a set of kinship relations—but fall short of becoming the day-to-day home in which all members of the household actually reside. Yet the material forms that people have built also mold their subjective experiences of ownership, belonging, and citizenship. It remains to be seen what it will take for “earthquake houses” to become homes.

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Comments

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In the aftermath of Hurricane Katrina, many residents of the Lower Ninth Ward remained without sufficient assistance to rebuild their homes partly because of the incongruence between state agencies' definition of property ownership and the complex informal practices of property succession among historically marginalized Black New Orleanians (Simerman 2020). Several years after a landslide decimated the community of San Juan de Grijalva in Chiapas, Mexico, survivors struggled with the affective discomfort their new homes caused them. Architects planning the Sustainable Rural City of Nuevo San Juan de Grijalva, as the State of Chiapas government christened the relocation site, had refused to design homes that followed local vernacular architecture, which featured porches in the front of the house, adjacent large main rooms for daily activities like eating and preparing meals, and bedrooms located in the most private spaces away from the main entrance. Instead, the planners placed the main bedroom adjacent to the street and the main entrance on the house's side and omitted the porches that defined the local vernacular style and served as a stage for daily socialization. San Juaneros who lived in these houses found them spatially illogical and spent what little resources they had in trying to retrofit them in the accustomed style (Barrios 2017a).

As Shneiderman and coauthors note in this article, during my very own dissertation fieldwork in southern Honduras after Hurricane Mitch, people displaced by the floods of the Choluteca River often refused to recognize the housing structures built under the management of international nongovernmental organizations (INGOs) as houses, often referring to them as matchboxes or shoeboxes. In this case, displaced families were assigned to live in a single room of 25 m² that was not structurally suited to the environmental conditions of the relocation site, was insufficient to meet the daily logistical and spatial needs of the majority of the affected families, and did not reflect the space- and place-making practices of working-

class Hondurans. The result: at least 25% of the housing structures built under the direction of INGOs were abandoned within a year of their construction.

As this small sample of countless instances around the globe demonstrates, concerns with the relevance of disaster aid to the housing, livelihood, identity, and comfort-making practices of impacted communities are a recurring theme in the evaluation and scholarly analysis of reconstruction programs. In this article, Shneiderman et al. deftly identify differences between governmental, anthropological, and local definitions and experiences of house, home, and household as a key sites where critical disjunctures in the distribution of disaster aid materialize. They also show us how these disjunctures, when left unattended, lead to the inefficient use of scarce recovery resources in the best of cases and the disruption of kinship-, economic-, identity-, and comfort-making practices in the worst. What is more, these authors also show how the imposition of governmental or INGO definitions of house, home, and household without proper modification to account for local practices, meanings, and feelings often constitutes an attempt to normalize and regulate the lifeways of disaster survivors—the effect being that housing reconstruction projects come to serve as a site of citizenship mediation where those who do not conform to institutional expectations of ownership and dwelling are systematically excluded from much-needed disaster aid. This is a keen analysis that demonstrates the power of ethnographically grounded anthropology to identify widespread—dare I say global—problems that require solutions that are informed by local practices and meanings.

In developing their argument, the authors also demonstrate how the critique of postdisaster reconstruction programs contributes to our anthropological understanding of houses as infrastructure that is always in the process of becoming and how culturally situated agency on the part of disaster survivors helps transform a housing space into a home: an affectively experienced space of identity, belonging, and well-being. In my own work in post-Mitch Honduras, I also recognized how predisaster house construction practices extended over time, with people adding rooms to their housing structures as they grew and obtained the means for expansions, with the result being that their houses served as families' material biographies. What cannot be understated here is the importance of understanding houses as processes that are not a mere backdrop or container of social action but are themselves a work of cultural practice where culturally contingent aspirations and values get negotiated with the agency of construction materials, with the effect of evoking sentiments of comfort and belonging. In fact, it is this specific understanding of “house” that many of the disaster survivors I interviewed in southern Honduras leaned on when reflecting on their own assessments of housing reconstruction programs. It was no accident that Honduran disaster survivors invoked a language of affect to critique the inability of imposed minimalist and environmentally unsuitable housing designs to produce the affective sentiments that indicated successful recovery for them: the feeling of *hallarse*,

to find oneself at ease in their sociomaterial environment (Barrios 2017a).

Shneiderman et al. have produced an article that elegantly identifies key challenges in postdisaster assistance and anthropological thought and also provide us with a clear path for praxis that is sensitive to varying practices of house, home, and household making wherever disaster may manifest. Only one question remains for me, however. The authors repeatedly state that disaster reconstruction in Nepal unfolded within the epistemic context of “development.” While I do recognize that disaster recovery is often taken on by governmental agencies and INGOs that rely on the knowledge-making categories and practices of development, in my experience, the context of disaster recovery often adds the additional complication of an accelerated project temporality often invoked by INGO workers to either pressure disaster survivors into accepting less than optimal terms of disaster recovery or justify limited disaster survivor input in project design and implementation. I am left to wonder in what ways the housing reconstruction projects in Nepal differed in either their temporal qualities (i.e., “accelerated development”) or other parameters and what implications these particular qualities of postdisaster development had for disaster-affected families.

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The article “House, Household, and Home” by Shneiderman, Limbu, Baniya, Suji, Rawal, and Warner, makes an important contribution to the postdisaster and reconstruction studies in Nepal and beyond. This article is the result of an ambitious comparative ethnography project covering multiple field sites in both urban and rural areas spread out in three districts. It is also the result of a “self-conscious” attempt at a large international joint research project involving researchers from multiple disciplines at different points in their career trajectories, who were trained and employed by universities and nongovernmental organizations (NGOs). To give a coherent structure to this ambitious project, the authors introduce a tripartite analytic framework consisting of the concepts of “house,” “household,” and “home.” They also explore the related Nepali concepts of *ghar* (house), *chulo* (hearth), and *gharduri* (legally registered household) at three different definitional scales: (1) a local conceptual framework, (2) a nationally implemented policy framework, and (3) anthropological theory. Their stated goal was to show why attention to the local conceptual framework is important for policy implementation and how anthropology might help mediate between local and national frameworks. The resulting article is characterized by both empirical richness and conceptual

clarity and will be a productive reference point for further debates in the field of postdisaster studies.

Such debates can be illustrated by comparing the article with Kharel and Nawa’s 2023 ethnographic study of postearthquake reconstruction focusing on a single village. The study presents intriguing contrasts, both conceptually and empirically, to that of Shneiderman et al. Kharel and Nawa (2023) chose not to use the analytic distinction between house and home because of the fact that people at their field site did not make this distinction. They stuck with local terms such as *dhunga ko ghar* (slate-roofed houses) and *bhukampa ghar* (earthquake-resistant houses) and argue that the same cultural devices are used to turn both kinds of physical structure into “dwellings.” Regarding the use of analytic terms, Nawa adds that he is “highly cautious about making such a bold schematization based on English terms [i.e., house, home, and household], even for heuristic purposes” (106, n3). On the empirical front, Shneiderman et al. characterize their overall findings as showing that the experience of postearthquake reconstruction highlighted conceptual problems with the existing legal definitions “and challenged people’s sense of belonging at the affective level.” Kharel and Nawa, in contrast, report that at their field site, despite the difficulties they had faced, the residents “seem to have a fundamentally positive view of post-earthquake ‘building’ and ‘dwelling,’ accepting *bhukampa ghar* as their new houses and homes by carrying out the house-moving ritual” (135). Thus, the paper by Kharel and Nawa, and potentially many other studies like this, demonstrates the diversity of postearthquake reconstruction processes and stimulates productive debates over some basic methodological questions in writing ethnography, such as how to choose descriptive and analytic terms when writing in English about non-English-speaking worlds.

Shneiderman et al. also wrote that postearthquake reconstruction could be approached through analytic frameworks that were used in the anthropological criticism of development in Nepal and cited, among others, Pigg (1992) and myself (Fujikura 2013). While I agree that there are definite overlaps between the anthropological criticisms of development and those of reconstruction, I believe that it will also be useful to remark on some of the differences between the two in terms of the goals of criticism. Shneiderman et al. highlight the conceptual difficulties with the legal definitions employed in the reconstruction process and state that one of their goals is to show how anthropological engagement might help mediate between policy and local frameworks. Pigg, in a series of important interventions, focused on how local frameworks for understanding everyday experiences were marginalized or “effaced” through the work of development (Pigg 1992, 1995, 1996, 1999). After describing numerous misinterpretations of local practices in the development literature, Pigg (1995) argued that it was not anthropologists’ task to try to correct those particular mistranslations in order to “tune-up” the “development machine” and “solve its functional glitches” (62). This is because those mistranslations are not simply due to insensitivity or mistakes but produced through a power asymmetry

embedded in development as a discursive formation that systematically devalues the local in contrast to what is presented as the universal. Pigg's call to anthropologists was not to "mediate" between the local and development frameworks but "to step outside the development paradigm all together" (62).

I chose a different direction. While acknowledging the power asymmetry between locals and the agents of development, I explored ways in which rural residents in Nepal were nonetheless engaged in creating new modes of exercising their agency in encounters with development, whether in producing and reproducing their family and kinship or in initiating an armed revolutionary movement or a nonviolent freedom movement for bonded laborers (Fujikura 2001, 2003, 2004, 2007). In this respect, I believe that I share a perspective with Shneiderman et al., as they characterize their project as an exploration of "a complex terrain of negotiation" inhabited by diverse actors "through which anthropological, policy, and experiential categories are *coproduced*" (emphasis added).

This brings me to my final point, which has to do with the important finding the article presents with reference to the case of Dolakha, where residents successfully changed the criteria for households eligible to receive relief aid. This case appears to have involved not so much the replacement of an administrative category with a local category but one administrative category (defined by an NGO) with another one similar to that used when collecting taxes (see Parajuli 2016). In this particular case, "mediation" by anthropologists seems unnecessary. Instead, this case directs our attention to whether or how we can connect such a case with the struggles for democratization and empowerment by the marginalized in Nepal over the past three decades and to the ways in which democratic struggles affect postdisaster processes or, conversely, how major disruptive events like disasters or violent conflicts might contribute to creating possibilities for people to construct new modes of sociopolitical engagement.

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Shneiderman et al.'s paper begins with the well- and long-known observation, especially in anthropology, that initiatives geared to fostering recovery following disaster often focus on rebuilding houses over re-creating a sense of home among beneficiaries. This study of Nepal following the 2015 earthquake adds empirical evidence to a large body of materials from the golden age of research on the topic back in the 1970s and 1980s. This is useful.

However, where Shneiderman and colleagues are really opening new paths is in that they go beyond the alleged divide beyond house and home to discuss how such concepts are

irrelevant in the local context and, even more importantly, that they support an imperialist agenda carried forward, consciously or not, by foreign organizations and imposed on local people by government agencies in the name of safety and risk reduction. As a result, survivors of the earthquake have been compelled to navigate a hybrid social and political environment where their own understanding of a dwelling coexists with that of foreign organizations and government agencies.

This coexistence is not easy or peaceful. Shneiderman and colleagues show that housing programs are often perceived as an aggression. The aggression is physical and brutal, with the construction of buildings that do not meet the expectations of local culture, but also more perversive, with the forcing of a translation of local terms into the terminology of Western donors, "an act of violence and reduction" (Young 2004:46), so that survivors can meet the criteria of a Western-influenced administration. As such, earthquake recovery programs can be seen as an opportunity for the government to strengthen its control over remote areas by bringing survivors into a matrix of knowledge that reflects normative expectations of everyday life, disaster risk reduction, and development. Expectations associated with concepts and categories such as house, home, and household that differ from local perspectives with such distinction between the Western dimensions of a dwelling do not make sense.

The existence of such difference between local perspectives and the normative agenda of foreign organizations and government agencies is essential, not only in exposing the inaccuracy of the recovery agenda but, more importantly, in unpacking the hybrid environment that survivors have had to navigate since the earthquake. Indeed, the introduction by foreign organizations and government agencies of earthquake-resistant buildings driven by alien technical expertise builds on a hierarchical understanding of both knowledge and people's ability to deal with natural phenomena—one that assumes that Western scientific knowledge is superior to local indigenous knowledge, whether such a divide actually exists.

However, the survivors, who are allegedly inferior, cannot be expected to fully absorb scientific knowledge and endorse new forms of architecture imposed by foreign organizations and government agencies, or it would undermine the very hierarchical ethos that underpins the recovery agenda. Hybridity is the inherent result of such tension or, in Bhabha's (1985) words, "the effect of an ambivalence produced within the rules of recognition of dominating discourses as they articulate the signs of cultural difference and reimplicate them within the deferential relations of colonial power-hierarchy, normalization, marginalization, and so forth" (153).

One may further argue that navigating this hybrid "third-space," to use another concept coined by Bhabha (1985), beyond the blunt binary distinction between expert and local knowledge, modernity and tradition, safety and danger, center and periphery, offers the survivors an opportunity to resist the initiatives imposed by foreign organizations and government agencies. The dwelling thus becomes a site of resistance to the exercise of power, in this particular case, the imposition of a

normative recovery agenda designed after the assumption that there is only one possible way of recovering from the disaster and dealing with future earthquakes.

Shneiderman and colleagues show that this resistance is explicit and frontal, as in the case of Dolakha. Yet it is also implicit and subversive. Indeed, it seems from the study that, oftentimes, survivors openly accept housing initiatives but eventually leverage the use of new structures to meet other everyday priorities and concerns, as in the case of Dhading and Sindhupalchowk. This “offstage” subversion of recovery initiatives is akin to Scott’s (1990) differentiation between public and hidden transcripts of resistance. In Scott’s (1989) own words, “resistance is virtually always a stratagem deployed by a weaker party in thwarting the claims of an institutional or class opponent who dominates the public exercise of power” (52). In that sense, the dwelling becomes a site of resistance because it opens up a thirdspace of ambivalence in Bhabha’s (1994) sense.

We have argued elsewhere (Gaillard 2021) that this form of resistance may be widespread although unreported for the very reason that those who subvert disaster risk reduction and recovery initiatives have all reasons for their response to remain unaccounted for, as per Scott’s (1990) detailed chronicles of peasants’ resistance to government policies in Southeast Asia. It is our contention that many people across diverse locations around the world tacitly and politely support shiny and allegedly successful disaster risk reduction and recovery projects imposed by foreign organizations and government agencies. However, in practice, the very same people leverage or even ignore the outputs and recommendations of these projects when it comes to actually dealing with natural phenomena that outside stakeholders call natural hazards.

This study of Nepal following the 2015 earthquake by Shneiderman and colleagues is important because it contributes to shedding light on such patterns of resistance that emphasize hybridity and ambivalence. It is a study that challenges what seems like common sense in the field of disaster studies and praxis of disaster risk reduction and recovery, that is, that there is a definitive way of dealing with an earthquake, based on a Western understanding of the world. As such, this study by Shneiderman and colleagues embodies and supports a broader agenda that many of us have put forward in our Disaster Studies Manifesto: “Power, Prestige and Forgotten Values” and its companion, a Disaster Studies Accord: “Priorities, Values and Relationships” (<https://www.radixonline.org/manifesto-accord>).

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As well as contributing to ongoing debates in anthropology about definitions of the house, the household, and the home, this article also sheds important light on patterns and practices of accountability in a low-income country, the importance of

whose relationship with external donors and development partners has been underlined by the exigencies of a disaster.

The manner and tone of the National Reconstruction Authority’s public presentation of its work suggests that the need to reassure donors that their money was well spent somewhat outweighed the state’s sense of its own accountability to the affected public, whose members had to present themselves to the authorities in ways that were not always consistent with their lived realities in order to access the reconstruction financing scheme. This lack of accountability was particularly evident in the cases of the so-called integrated settlements built for a number of severely affected and relocated communities, as described in detail by Baniya (2021) and more briefly by others, including Gurung (2022) and Hutt and Shreesh (2019). Further research might very usefully explore the implications of relocating communities whose pattern of physical settlement has evolved over many generations in a social geography dictated by economics, history, caste, class, and gender to new settlements consisting of serried ranks of identical structures.

In the disaster studies discourse the point is repeatedly made that disasters are always created by humans. In the case of a natural hazard event such as an earthquake, the disaster is a consequence of inadequacies in a society’s state of preparedness for the event, or of the inadequacy or inappropriateness of its response to that event, rather than a consequence of the natural event itself. That beneficiaries had to work with unfamiliar categories and frameworks and experienced outcomes that did not necessarily fulfil their needs was a consequence of the fact that the reconstruction program was conceived without taking earthquake-affected people’s deeply embedded conceptions of house, home, and household sufficiently into account.

Nearly 30 years ago, Albala-Bertrand (1993) argued that “the endogenous response” was too often overlooked in writings on disaster response: “For some authors, the ongoing social system often appears as a nuisance to the visible response represented in prominent national and international organizations. This lopsidedness feeds the technologically biased approach to disaster response, at the expense of political and socio-economic structure and dynamics” (23). In our introduction to a recent edited volume on the Nepal earthquake aftermath, Mark Liechty and I (2021) have argued, similarly, that the effectiveness of interventions will be limited if they ignore local sociocultural processes and contexts and that to be effective, “disaster relief has to amplify the agency of the disaster-affected, not that of the disaster experts” (16).

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The article by Shneiderman et al. makes a number of contributions to the anthropology of policy, disaster, and the house.

Here, I would like to focus on the article's implications for the applied anthropology of policy. Importantly, the authors provide an exploratory approach to policy grounded in the perspective of impacted communities instead of framing them as a problem to be "managed" through policy (Tate 2020:94). According to the participants in this impressive multisited and multiyear study, the problem is how policy excludes certain kinds of households and causes confusion in the rebuilding process. As a result, recipients are caught in a "seemingly unending cycle of building and rebuilding" that often produces a "patchwork built environment." For residents, reconstruction requirements rarely meet their social, aesthetic, or economic needs, even resulting for some in the construction of effective nonhomes (called "earthquake," "grant," or "government" houses) lacking the experiential belonging of an *aphno ghar*, or "real house." Building on the article's resident-centric critique of theory and policy, I would like to propose how it might also offer lessons for the methods and practice of policy anthropology.

Refreshingly, the authors' use of theory is not directly taken from academic debates and inserted into policy suggestions. Instead, in what Baba (2000) might call a "feedback" model of theory and practice, the policy suggestions emerge from a simultaneous critique of theory and policy. As the authors demonstrate, the problematic use of "household" and "house" in policy is rooted in a more foundational disconnect within anthropology that has often failed to integrate the divergent interpretations of house, household, and home. The article incorporates the conceptual triad of house/household/home within the infrastructure-as-process theoretical turn to argue for how both the material house and the social home are produced through affective labor. This intriguing turn is based on the article's ethnographic exploration of the three concepts, demonstrating how they become coconstituted through the seemingly opposite constructs of dwelling and mobility, belonging, and migration.

Turning from disciplinary critique to policy, the authors identify a problematic use of household in international development. Much like how the use of "culture" in popular discourse has remained attached to the bounded-group definition long discarded by anthropology, the National Reconstruction Authority's "uncritically embedded" use of household suffers from an outdated universalism that conflates it with the physical house and land ownership. Consequently, Nepal's reconstruction policy often disenfranchises the multiple households living under one roof in urban settings and the translocal households in rural settings.

Wading into applied waters, the authors conclude their critique by making several recommendations for reconstruction policy: (1) to consider the context-specific meaning of terms; (2) to account for temporal aspects of engagement with policy—before, during, and after disaster; and (3) to move away from an "owner-driven" model of reconstruction given the ambiguities of ownership. These are significant and necessary suggestions. We can only hope that policymakers are

taking note, but the uneven legacy of anthropologists working in policy suggests otherwise (Andersson 2018; Besteman 2010). As my students (seeking master's degrees in applied anthropology) often remind me when reading critiques of policy, there is a wide gulf between policy suggestions and actual changes. Although application is beyond the already expansive scope of the article—and perhaps the authors have addressed interventions and advocacy in some other publication or policy brief—I would like to propose one additional route for research intervention.

While the policy recommendations occupy much of the article's conclusion, the authors make a subtle hint to a different kind of outcome earlier in the piece that left me thinking about alternative possibilities. Near the end of the article, the authors refer to a "collective community complaint" that successfully secured equal resources for a number of households in Dolakha. In response to "false victims" accusations, the community apparently protested against the household registration process, echoing, the authors tell us, scholarly critiques of neo-classical models. This sort of collective organizing suggests an additional kind of labor that supplements the meaning of home and also serves as a model for how anthropological applications might seek to change policy.

In my research on house construction and land buying in prequake/periurban Kathmandu, I found a parallel to this article's distinction between the earthquake/government (non-home) house and *aphno ghar*. Similar to how reconstruction policy led to the construction of separate one-story structures, I found that the regulation of building code and economic pressures of city life influenced periurban residents to build houses focused on passing inspections and finding paying tenants. Often because of these influences, few thought of their city house as a *ghar*, or a more holistic notion of home they reserved for village life. In particular, the city house lacked the support and cooperation of village home communities, social features rarely present in their growing periurban neighborhoods. Nostalgia for the village—albeit often romanticized from the city—tended to be most frequently referenced during times of infrastructural demand when residents attempted to meet shared needs of road, electricity, and water access. The better-organized neighborhoods—socially and materially—tended to have stronger notions of their residence as a *ghar*, suggesting that the labor of home-making entailed emotional-, material-, and community-based efforts.

This more collective meaning of home offers an additional critique of the "owner-driven" rebuilding model (beyond the ambiguities of ownership) to consider the role of community networks in rebuilding. In terms of methodology, it also suggests the possibility of a participatory approach to applied scholarship. The article's resident-centric approach demonstrates the promise of a collaborative approach to theorization and critique. In doing so, it plants the seeds for considering how research might support community-based responses to policy, not just as critics but also as agents of transformation.

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In late March 2020, the UK government grudgingly responded to the Covid-19 pandemic by imposing the first national lockdown. People were told not to leave their homes unless it was for grocery shopping, medical reasons, or essential work. In October 2020, a group of anthropologists from the London School of Economics, led by Laura Bear, produced a report, criticizing these measures for cutting off networks of care that did not coincide with the government's assumptions about households in the UK. The rules effectively discriminated against women, who bore the brunt of caring responsibilities amid school closures, and working class and ethnic minority groups that rely on extended family networks to provide care work and support each other.

The cases examined in this article are not about the pandemic but a different kind of disaster: an earthquake. It is also about Nepal, not the UK. Nevertheless, the arguments that the authors put forward about the discrepancy between policymakers and citizens around definitions of the house, household, and home in postearthquake Nepal resonates with phenomena observed elsewhere. The authors write that the "reconstruction guidelines therefore reified the notion of *gharduri* as the only legally recognizable form of household by linking it in a one-on-one manner to the individual physical unit of the house and, further, to the land on which it sat." This understanding of the household did not match with the reality of how people across Nepal lived with multiple households under the same roof in urban areas or how single households existed across different houses in rural areas.

Shneiderman and her coauthors write that "houses mediate . . . between people and their systems of governance." This is recognizable as a story of modernity. As Michel Foucault (2007) and Nikolas Rose (1999:74) have demonstrated, the household and the family have been key technologies of discipline and "responsibilization." But these classic analyses did not focus greatly on the materiality of the house or on the affective aspects of the home. By attending to the legal and bureaucratic processes of reconstruction that hinge on questions of property ownership and registration in postearthquake Nepal, the authors effectively show that materiality and sociality are entangled in the household. This ethnographically informed perspective reveals that households are not simply means of disciplining citizens. Conceived in conjunction with the infrastructural house and the affective sense of home, "the household" can literally enable or curtail life. This depends on whether people's practices of maintaining their households fit with those of governmental expectations.

The Nepalese government created guidelines requiring legal certificates of land ownership predating the 2015 earthquake in order to receive housing reconstruction grants. The au-

thors show that many residents in their field sites did not have the kind of paperwork that made their households legible to the state, thereby excluding them from reconstruction grants. In addition, as land ownership became the basis for making claims for grants, the many mobile people across Nepal, as well as women, were disqualified. The authors show with persuasive detail how the household as a material, relational, and affective unit could become an avenue for survival if it fit the reconstruction framework but a site of destitution if it did not. We see in postearthquake Nepal that when the house, the household, and the home do not map onto each other in the eyes of the state, people become illegible and therefore ineligible for reconstruction grants—ineligible for a secure future.

The challenge here is one that scholars have seen in other development regimes. Anthropologists have demonstrated how international aid agencies as well as state actors operate as bureaucracies with managerial systems that demand standardization in the name of equality, accountability, and even participation (Green 2003; Li 2011). The aid agencies and government bodies in postearthquake Nepal appear to function in similar ways, delimiting "the household" as a unit that can be quantified, measured, and evaluated in a bureaucracy. As such, there is a fundamental incompatibility between policy's view of households as static categories that can be captured in spreadsheets and reports versus people's experiences of households as ever-changing, lived, and ambiguous.

Ultimately, this discrepancy is moralized: not meeting the state's definitions indicates that people are not legitimate victims or beneficiaries. The starting point of the reconstruction guidelines seems to be a culture of suspicion toward claimants. The authors explain that in their field sites people are highly mobile, migrating to other places and countries in order to earn money and make ends meet for their families. Yet this reality is the basis for the government's suspicion of potential beneficiaries. As seen in development aid and asylum procedures in other parts of the world, bureaucratic norms are therefore technologies not only of discipline but also of morality, serving as "evidence" of the deceitful and delinquent character of a certain group of people when they do not meet those norms.

The authors' findings that the household is central to the politics of disaster resonates with my own research on disaster preparedness. If the household is central to reconstruction, as well as for disaster response and preparedness, what are the implications of this? In my research in Japan, I have found that focusing on the household as the key site of preparedness places unfair unburden on women to mitigate disaster risks by relying on and entrenching expectations of their domestic and reproductive labor. I suggest that there is a kind of "feminization of preparedness," akin to the "feminization of responsibility and obligation" in poor households and in antipoverty projects (Chant 2008; Molyneux 2006). The authors of this article problematize the government's and aid agencies' (mis) understandings of the relationship between house, household,

and home, but they do not question this policy focus itself. I would be interested to learn more about the potential unintended consequences of this attention on the household. Paraphrasing James Ferguson (1994) in his study of development programs in Lesotho, while the stated aim of “owner-driven” reconstruction failed, what unintended effects might have been achieved?

Reply

We were pleased to receive such thorough and thoughtful comments from colleagues with a wide range of thematic and geographic expertise. It is especially gratifying that both commentators immersed in disaster research broadly conceived (Barrios, Gaillard, Watanabe) and those whose research engages directly with Nepal’s experiences of development and transformation (Fujikura, Hutt, Nelson) found our arguments and empirical material of value. Collectively, the commentators emphasize that our analysis of the tripartite relationship between house, household, and home at multiple scales effectively draws out local detail and contextual issues to illuminate how disaster-affected people exercise agency in relation to their environment and community, as well as state and nonstate actors. This response validates our sensibility that when paired with an analysis of institutional frameworks at local, national, and international scales, place-based ethnography can yield richly textured understanding relevant to both anthropological theory-building and global policy application.

Since we conducted our research and finalized this article, which appears more or less in its accepted form dating to April 2021, a wide range of literature has been published on Nepal’s 2015 earthquakes and the country’s subsequent recovery and reconstruction. Various commentators helpfully cite some of this material, and we would like to highlight two further bibliographic resources. One is our own partnership’s research guide, “Reconstructing Nepal: The 2015 Earthquakes and Their Aftermath,” housed at the University of British Columbia Library.²⁶ Another is “Nepal Earthquake 2015 and Its Aftermath: A bibliographic resource guide—update 2022” prepared by one of our coauthors, Jeevan Baniya, and Amit Gautam at Social Science Baha in Kathmandu, in collaboration with the School of Oriental and African Studies–based project, “After the Earth’s Violent Sway,” for whom one of the commentators on this article, Michael Hutt, served as principal investigator.²⁷

We mention these resources both to direct interested readers to additional information that we could not cite directly and to emphasize that scholarly knowledge production in and about Nepal is robust and constitutes its own “epistemic ter-

rain” to a significant extent, to use a term introduced in the article and debated by some of the commentators. Indeed, one of our goals has been to connect the dots between Nepal-based research, global anthropological theory, and policy practice.

Tatsuro Fujikura’s commentary productively expands these connections by putting our piece in conversation with a recently published article in *Studies in Nepali History and Society* (SINHAS) by Dipesh Kharel and Katsuo Nawa (2023). SINHAS is the flagship journal of Martin Chautari, a research institute based in Kathmandu that publishes social science and humanities scholarship about Nepal, in both English and Nepali. Kharel and Nawa’s article in SINHAS takes up questions similar to ours about postearthquake housing reconstruction and extensively references the preprint version of the present article. By centering much of his commentary on a shared analysis of our two articles, Fujikura emphasizes the need for ongoing collaboration, transparency, and intentional citation practices to ensure that publications about Nepal in journals based in the Global North, such as *Current Anthropology*, engage in-depth with scholarly production in the country itself.

We strongly support this approach while also questioning the implication that our English-language analytical categories of house, household, and home are somehow less appropriate than Kharel and Nawa’s choice of *ghar*, *bhukampa ghar*, and *dhungako ghar*. These terms circulate in local Nepali-language discourse and are clearly the relevant ones in Alampu, Dolakha, where Kharel and Nawa conducted their research. But we note that they do not carry shared meaning universally across Nepal, as our own disparate research findings about the different implication of *bhukampa ghar* in Dhading demonstrate. As ours was a multisited study that engaged with residents across three districts of the country, as well as taking policy actors as subjects in themselves, some kind of heuristic choice was required to bring diverse terminologies and experiences into productive conversation within a shared analytical frame.

Further, using terminology in English that connects resident-centric experiences (to use Nelson’s term) with extant policy categories enables insights from Nepal-based research to travel effectively into spaces of global disaster risk reduction policymaking—a move that both Barrios and Gaillard affirm is welcome. Kharel and Nawa, too, seem to recognize the value of such terminologies for theory-building purposes, through their own invocation of Tim Ingold’s categories of “building” and “dwelling,” which do not seem to have any obvious Nepali-language cognates—although they certainly express observed sensibilities among earthquake-affected people, just as “house,” “household,” and “home” do. In cases like both the ones described in our article and that described by Kharel and Nawa, where such terminologies emerge from place-based ethnography conducted by researchers competent in relevant languages, we believe that deploying such analytical categories in English is justifiable to enable connections not only with global anthropological audiences interested in theory-building but also with policy audiences across the world.

26. <https://guides.library.ubc.ca/reconstructingnepal>.

27. <https://sway.sosc.baha.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/05/nepal-earthquake-2015-and-its-aftermath-update-2022.pdf>.

Several commentators productively expand our consideration of the affective and material transformations wrought by the “owner-driven reconstruction” model implemented by Nepal’s National Reconstruction Authority (NRA). Chika Watanabe critically emphasizes the gendered dimensions of an ownership-based approach to reconstruction, closing her reflection with an important question: “while the stated aim of ‘owner-driven’ reconstruction failed, what unintended effects might have been achieved?” Before answering, we wish to clarify that we do not believe that the program failed, and our article does not make this argument. Rather, to borrow a helpful phrase from David Mosse (2005:19), we offer a rich empirical evidence base to show what kinds of “project effects” it has actually had. These include the construction of a patchwork built environment where people have diversified their residential and livelihood portfolios across multiple kinds of structures—old and new, less and more earthquake resilient—as well as the procedural reification of “ownership” as the basis for citizenship, understood as the ability to make claims on the state.

All of this, Watanabe suggests, is interesting but does not address the fundamental question of why policy actors have selected the scale of individual, presumably heteronormative families—whether signified by house, household, or home—as the fundamental unit for aid distribution, rather than something more expansive. What might it look like to “build back otherwise” (Seale-Feldman 2020)? This intriguing possibility is also raised by Andrew Nelson, who “offers an additional critique of the ‘owner-driven’ rebuilding model (beyond the ambiguities of ownership) to consider the role of community networks in rebuilding.” Taken together, Watanabe and Nelson seem to be saying that we must not only ask how the categories of house, household, and home are interpreted and linked to material resources and affective outcomes—as our article has done—but also zoom out further to question the very fact that the logic of reconstruction is grounded in a Eurocentric liberal individual notion of the household as a discrete unit, rather than a more inclusive, collective notion of community.

It is indeed an interesting thought experiment to consider what Nepal’s physical and social landscape would look like now had the NRA and its international donors considered alternatives to individual ownership as the basis of eligibility for aid. What if communities (whether defined by administrative, territorial, kinship, or other markers) were asked to develop proposals for future well-being as a collectivity, in ways that rewarded mutual support, whether through traditional systems such as *parma* (labor exchange) or newer ideas such as *samavesikaran* (inclusion)? Could such approaches provide a counterpoint to the reductive individualism inherent in an owner-driven approach, highlighting instead the power of collectivity and collaboration to ensure more equitable access to resources for all, regardless of relative claims to landownership?

Such questions resonate with emergent conversations elsewhere in the world around Indigenous-led disaster and emergency response. In one example from a First Nations

jurisdiction in Canada, Emma Feltes, Jocelyn Stacey, and their coauthors from the T̓silhqot’in National Government (2023), show how Indigenous approaches to emergency management foreground lateral, largely nonhierarchical collaboration between diverse people, as well as between people and their environment, in ways that push back against statist conceptualizations of “emergency” as an opportunity to assert singular, hegemonic power. Such alternative imaginings of emergency response protocols that value existing community networks and resources, and envision recovery beyond the individual or the family, suggest that there is broad scope for reconfiguring disaster risk reduction policies to embrace forms of collectivity beyond the heteronormative household, in ways aligned with what both Nelson and Watanabe have suggested here.

Feltes, Stacey, and the T̓silhqot’in National Government (2023) make another critical intervention relevant to the highly political context of our work in Nepal. Conversely, we believe that our material from Nepal—as a small part of the now substantive body of research on disaster governance in the Global South—is relevant to such considerations in Canada and elsewhere in the Global North, and we wish to advocate for scholarly exchange in all directions. Feltes, Stacey, and the T̓silhqot’in National Government (2023) argue that declarations of emergency provide a convenient cover for the Canadian government to retreat to its “constitutional habits” of exercising authority over First Nations jurisdiction. This is the case even following the successful 2014 T̓silhqot’in claim to Aboriginal title in the Supreme Court and the subsequent federal commitment to honoring the Calls to Action of the 2015 Report of the Truth and Reconciliation Commission. The authors show how during both wildfire and pandemic crises that hit T̓silhqot’in territory, state actors reverted to outmoded, oppressive paradigms for engagement with Indigenous communities, despite clear knowledge of how things should be different given the changed legal and jurisdictional landscape. They justified such actions as appropriate during times of “emergency,” using the logic of “crisis epistemology” (Whyte 2020) to argue problematically that urgent responses to humanitarian crises cannot be held to the government’s own standards of accountability.

For Nepal, like Canada, 2015 was a year of radical political transformation. The earthquakes occurred in spring of that year, during a long, drawn-out process of postconflict federal state restructuring following the Maoist-state civil conflict from 1996 to 2006. Nearly a decade after the conflict ended, the promised new constitution still had not materialized by the time of the seismic disaster. Within months, a new constitution was finally promulgated in September 2015, its final contours shaped by the disaster in the sense that “the earthquake aftermath provided the section of the political elite that had the upper hand at that juncture with an opportunity to deliver a constitutional settlement that might not otherwise have been supported across the country” (Hutt 2020:395). The new constitution was intended to devolve power to local authorities, creating a more inclusive polity in response to the

grievances of erstwhile Maoist combatants, as well as Indigenous and Madhesi regional rights activists. But the actualities of the new federal structure left plenty of room for state actors to revert to older habits as the constitution and the reconstruction program were implemented contemporaneously. Notably, the approximately 3,000 engineers initially deputed by the NRA to assess need and enroll beneficiaries in the housing reconstruction program reported directly to the federal authority, with only limited responsibilities devolved to new local governments relatively late in the reconstruction process. In this way, in Nepal as in Canada, despite highly visible commitments to honor Indigenous and local jurisdictions as part of the reconciliation and postconflict state restructuring processes, respectively, the urgency of disaster response was used as a backstage opportunity to consolidate discredited forms of centralized state power.

This reality echoes points made by Barrios and Gaillard about the power dynamics inherent in humanitarian projects and their relationship with the adjacent field of development. Barrios inquires about the different temporalities of disaster response and development, suggesting that the former might be understood through the lens of “accelerated development.” This is a helpful concept that highlights the deadline-driven nature of the housing reconstruction program in Nepal, like many disaster response initiatives elsewhere. Drawing on the argument made in the preceding paragraphs, we would emphasize, however, that it was not the material urgency of relieving disaster-affected people’s suffering that occasioned the acceleration of development through housing reconstruction in Nepal’s case but rather the political urgency of consolidating state power at a time of erstwhile devolution, as well as placating donors, whose continued support was critical to both the infrastructural and governance agendas of the Nepali state itself. Along these lines, our intention in situating the problematics of postdisaster housing reconstruction within the epistemic terrain of development is to show how the self-definition of humanitarianism as an apolitical field responding to urgent life safety needs may be misguided, because it is often (at least in contexts like Nepal) embedded in existing developmentalist narratives and their political corollaries.

We wish to emphasize that these narratives have been promoted primarily by the Nepali state itself—surely in relation to the imperatives of external actors but not wholly driven by them. This insight is critical in reframing the negotiation of power that occurs in the space of postdisaster reconstruction as a triangular one, between affected people, their state, and external forces. Indeed, this is the shape of the “thirdspace” that Gaillard refers to, a hybrid formation that troubles received binaries such as domination/resistance, modernity/tradition, safety/danger, West/rest. Rather than framing disaster response as an enabler of “imperialism” or “Western influence,” we see it is a space where hegemonic states themselves may mobilize external resources to enforce existing paradigms of internal oppression. Yet at the same time, the hybridity of the thirdspace, and the global entanglements of everyone who inhabits

it—from disaster-affected people to policymakers in national and global metropolitan centers—opens up possibilities for negotiation, even across hierarchies and inequalities.

As Fujikura notes, we center this complex terrain of negotiation through which anthropological, policy, and experiential categories are *coproduced*. In so doing, we are not suggesting that anthropological mediation between people and their states is necessary to achieve immediate goals like more equitable distribution of immediate relief. Instead, we hope that the power and agency produced through the multidirectional negotiations that disaster-affected people must undertake, and anthropological representations of it in spaces like this journal, may have some small effect on future policy processes so that communities everywhere experience fewer searing disjunctures between life as lived and the categories within which it must be made legible.

—Sara Shneiderman, Bina Khapunghang Limbu,
Jeevan Baniya, Manoj Suji, Nabin Rawal,
Prakash Chandra Subedi, and Cameron David Warner

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